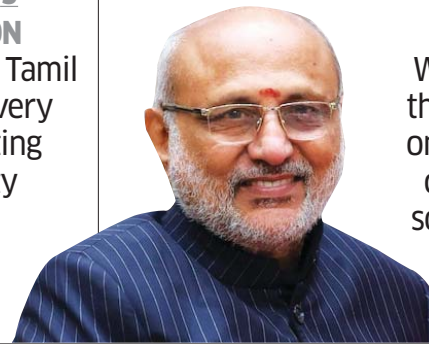


PAGE 5
NATION



Rijiju calls Tamil Nadu a very interesting society

PAGE 6
NATION



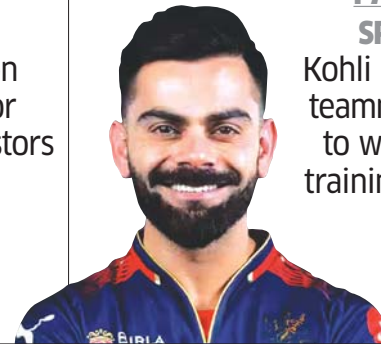
World under threat of war, only dialogue can lead to solutions: VP

PAGE 9
GLOBAL



Jury finds Elon Musk liable for misleading investors

PAGE 11
SPORTS



Kohli urges RCB teammates not to waste any training session

AGENDA



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PIONEER IN SHORT

AIRLINES FREED FROM PRICE LIMITS

The Ministry of Civil Aviation has withdrawn fare caps introduced during IndiGo's flight disruptions last December, effective Monday, citing stabilisation of operations and restored capacity, officials said on Saturday. The move follows airlines' appeals amid rising operating costs linked to the West Asia conflict. The caps, which limited fares to ₹7,500 for routes up to 500 km, ₹12,000 for 500-1,000 km, ₹15,000 for 1,000-1,500 km, and ₹18,000 for longer sectors, were imposed after large-scale IndiGo cancellations led to steep price surges. Business-class tickets and flights under the regional UDAN scheme were exempt. The ministry said airlines must continue to maintain discipline in fare-setting, ensuring prices remain reasonable, and transparent.

India pushes peace in PM Modi-Iran President talks

ASHOKE RAJ
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday held talks with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, extending greetings on the occasions of Nowruz and Eid while also addressing the rapidly evolving security situation in West Asia. PM Modi strongly condemned attacks on essential infrastructure, underlining the risks they pose to both regional stability and the continuity of global supply chains, during the call. He further emphasised the importance of maintaining freedom of navigation and keeping vital maritime routes open, including the Strait of Hormuz. The discussion comes amid heightened tensions in West Asia, raising concerns about regional stability, energy security and safety of critical international shipping routes. "Spoke with President Dr Masoud Pezeshkian and conveyed Eid and Nowruz greetings. We expressed hope that this festive season brings peace, stability and prosperity to West Asia. Condemned



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attacks on critical infrastructure in the region, which threaten regional stability and disrupt global supply chains. Reiterated the importance of safeguarding freedom of navigation and ensuring that shipping lanes remain open and secure. Appreciated Iran's continued support for the safety and security of Indian nationals in Iran," the PM posted on X following the conversation. This marked the second high-level conversation between PM Modi and President Pezeshkian since the onset of conflict in late February. Their earlier interaction, on March 12, involved a

detailed briefing by the Iranian President on the internal situation in Iran and his perspective on broader regional developments. Throughout the conversation, PM Modi expressed concerns over the continuing violence and reiterated the need to avoid further escalation. He reaffirmed India's consistent call for dialogue and diplomacy as the primary path to resolve conflicts and maintain peace. The conversation with Tehran is part of India's broader and sustained diplomatic effort to respond to the conflict. In recent days, the PM has engaged with leaders from the United Arab Emirates, Israel, Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Qatar and Oman. These exchanges have focused on three key priorities: protecting the large Indian diaspora, ensuring uninterrupted energy supplies, and advocating for de-escalation through diplomatic channels. Follow-up discussions with several global leaders reinforced India's stance that prolonged conflict could have consequences far beyond the immediate region.

Nuclear site in Iran targeted

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Iran on Saturday confirmed a joint US-Israel strike on a critical nuclear facility approximately 220 kilometers southeast of Tehran. The incident occurred at the Shahid Ahmadi Roshan uranium enrichment site near Natanz, according to Iran's Atomic Energy Organisation. The organisation emphasised that there was no release of radioactive material and no immediate threat to nearby communities, according to an official statement carried by Iran's *Tasnim* news agency. Satellite imagery, however, shows damage to one of the facility's buildings. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) confirmed that Iran had informed it of the attack. The UN nuclear watchdog reported no elevated radiation levels outside the facility and said it is monitoring the situation closely.

LPG boost for hotels, canteens

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Union Government on Saturday increased the allocation of commercial LPG by an additional 20 per cent bringing up the total allocation to 50 per cent. The additional allocation will be subject to commercial establishments registering with Oil Marketing Companies (OMC) and applying for Piped Natural Gas (PNG) connection, according to a letter written by the oil secretary to States. "The additional allocation of 20 per cent shall be given



People wait in a queue for LPG cooking gas cylinders in Noida PTI

on priority to the following sectors—restaurants, dhabas, hotels, industrial canteen, food processing/dairy, subsidised canteens/outlets run by State Governments or local bodies for food, community kitchens, 5kg FTL for migrant laborers along with measures to ensure no diversion," the letter read.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Mamata slams BJP over voter rights

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister (CM) Mamata Banerjee on Saturday accused the BJP-led Union Government snatching away voting rights through the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), and described Prime Minister Narendra Modi as the biggest infiltrator, intensifying tensions ahead of polls. Addressing a gathering after Eid prayers at Kolkata's Red Road, Banerjee said her



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee addressing a gathering in Kolkata on Saturday PTI

party would resist any attempt to dilute electoral rights. "We will not allow Modi ji and the BJP to take away your voting rights. We will fight till the end," she said. Framing the upcoming polls as a battle to protect democratic rights and the State's plural social fabric, Banerjee alleged that names of genuine voters — particularly from minority-dominated areas — had been removed during the SIR exercise.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



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CM Rekha felicitates 56 UPSC qualifiers at Janseva Sadan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday felicitated 56 meritorious youths who cleared the Civil Services Examination at the 'Delhi ke Gaurav: UPSC Achievers Felicitation Ceremony 2026', held at the Mukhyamantri Janseva Sadan.

During the event, the Chief Minister interacted with the qualifiers, learning about their experiences, struggles, and journey to success, while extending her best wishes for their bright future.

Organised for the first time by the Delhi Government in collaboration with the Revenue Department, the

ceremony also saw the presence of the candidates' parents — a move lauded as a commendable new initiative by the state.

The Chief Minister engaged with the family members to understand their perspectives and emotions regarding their children's achievements. Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma, Divisional Commissioner Neeraj Semwal, and other dignitaries were also present at the occasion.

The Chief Minister remarked that through their relentless hard work, discipline, and unwavering determination, these youngsters have not only brought pride to their families but also to the entire city and the nation.

She emphasised that this achievement is not merely a personal success but a significant step toward nation-building.

Addressing the gathering, she stated that these newly selected officers will serve as the backbone of the country's administrative system and will play a crucial role in taking developmental schemes to the person at the last mile of society. She added that their dedication, struggle, and spirit of service will serve as a source of inspiration for future generations.

The Chief Minister clarified that the Civil Services should not be seen merely as a means to gain authority but as an opportunity for pur-



poseful service. "Real change is only possible when authority is coupled with a sense of purpose," she noted.

The Chief Minister affirmed that the Delhi Government is continuously working to make the capital's education system more robust, inclusive, and competitive, ensuring that a significant number of IAS, IPS, and other officers emerge from Delhi every year. She stated that the government aims to create an academic environment where every student has access to quality education, proper guidance, and the necessary resources for competitive exams.

She mentioned that the ongoing reforms in the edu-

cation sector are not limited to exam success but also aim to instil leadership qualities, sensitivity, and a spirit of service in students. Reiterating the government's commitment, the chief minister said the goal is to ensure that no talented student is left behind due to a lack of resources.

During the programme, the Chief Minister discussed preparation experiences, challenges, and suggestions with the 56 selected candidates. She stated that the insights of the youth serve as a guide for the government and will be incorporated into policy-making to provide better opportunities for future generations.

Police bust ISI espionage racket, nine arrested

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Sustained investigation followed by relentless raids has yielded results as Uttar Pradesh Police and security agencies picked up nine people, including five minors, in connection with the espionage racket being run by the notorious Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) of Pakistan.

As per the available information, at least nine people, including four adults, were arrested, and five minors aged 15-17 from UP and Bihar were detained, bringing the total in custody to 15.



Ganesh Giri (20, Nepal origin), Vivek Rai/Vivek (18, Purnia, Bihar), Gagan Prajapati (22, Meerut), and Durgesh Nishad (26, Jaunpur/Nav Mumbai) were arrested, while five unnamed juveniles (15-17 years) have been detained for questioning, an official said.

Earlier, Ghaziabad Police had arrested six accused persons, including mastermind Sohail/Suhel Malik and Sane Iram alias Mehek. They are in police custody and being interrogated to get to the bottom of the conspiracy of the Pakistan ISI to infiltrate the solar-powered cameras installed at key locations to monitor the movement of

the armed forces. remain in custody. Two key suspects identified as Naushad Ali, a resident of Muzaffarpur, and Sameer alias Shooter, a resident of Bhagalpur in Bihar, are still absconding.

Police have recovered at least 2 solar-powered SIM-enabled CCTV cameras installed at Delhi Cantonment and Sonapat Railway Station (one streamed live for 18 days), multiple phones, SIMs, and documents from the arrested people.

The probe by the Special Investigation Team (SIT) has found that the ISI-run network was planning over 50 such cameras across India; ISI handlers were paying ₹500-15,000 per task via WhatsApp to the recruits.

tion, allowing real-time monitoring of troop movements, which posed a severe risk to India's defence infrastructure. To further avoid raising suspicions, the cell reportedly hired Hindu youths to carry out the installations. This tactic was designed to blend into everyday activities and dodge scrutiny from authorities.

Initially, six persons, Suhel Malik, Iram alias Mahak, Praveen, Raj Valmiki, Shiva Valmiki, and Ritik Gangwar, were arrested. These suspects were allegedly sharing photos, videos, and precise locations of security force bases and railway stations with foreign contacts, receiving payments in return.

Central security agencies in consonance with Uttar Pradesh Police and other state police forces have launched an intense operation to unravel the full extent of this espionage ring. This well-entrenched ring was busted amid heightened concerns over cross-border intelligence operations, and it has successfully thwarted what could have been a catastrophic breach of national security.

This incident highlights the evolving methods of foreign adversaries in infiltrating India's defences through tech-

nology and local recruits.

The unravelling of this module has once again brought the modus operandi of the ISI to identify and entrap foot soldiers by using devious means. A senior official said that one of the easy routes to trap the future recruits is to first spread rumours by unverified social media posts and then start the grooming of the selected targets for initial contact (even a simple friend request on SM platforms).

Influencers and YouTubers such as Jyoti Malhotra were groomed by the ISI for propaganda and gathering intelligence by innocuous travels. These modus operandi involve lower risk, wider reach and targeting tech professionals, students or anyone with a smartphone.

These methods were clearly on display in the Ghaziabad spy ring (15 arrests so far, solar cameras, WhatsApp handlers, and minors involved) — a textbook low-budget technical HUMINT module. Indian agencies (IB, NIA, state police) counter this through raids, SIM tracing, digital forensics, and expulsions from the High Commission. Cases often lead to arrests under the Official Secrets Act.

City remains under grip of chilly winds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Even as the maximum temperature of Delhi saw a significant increase on Saturday, the national Capital remained under the influence of chilly winds, a day after Delhi recorded its coldest March day in six years and the cleanest air day in five months.

Safdarjung, representative of Delhi's weather, recorded a minimum of 13 degrees Celsius, 3.5 degrees below the normal and a drop from 16 degrees Celsius recorded on Friday.

The maximum temperature was recorded at 27.4 degrees Celsius, 3.9 degrees above the normal and a 5.7 degrees increase from Friday's maximum temperature of 21.7 degrees Celsius.

Delhi had logged its coldest March day since March 8, 2020, when the mercury had dropped to 21.2 degrees Celsius.

Meanwhile, other weather stations also marked a significant increase in the maximum temperature and a further dip in the minimum temperature. Palam recorded a maximum of 26.3 degrees Celsius, 5.3 degrees below the normal and a 5.1 degree increase from the



day before. The minimum at Palam was recorded at 13.5 degrees Celsius, 2.9 degrees below the normal and a 1.2 degrees drop from the day before.

Lodhi Road recorded a maximum and minimum temperature of 27 degrees Celsius and 13 degrees Celsius, respectively.

The maximum was a six-degree increase from Friday, and the minimum was 2.8 degrees lower than the day before.

"Continuous rainfall on March 18, 19 and 20 led to a significant increase in moisture content in the lower levels of the atmosphere. Following overnight clearing of the skies, there was strong cooling of the ground, which in turn cooled the air

close to the surface.

As the air cooled, it lost its capacity to hold moisture, leading to condensation of water vapour into tiny droplets and resulting in the formation of mild to moderate fog over Delhi-NCR," said Mahesh Palawat, vice president at Skymet.

"Going ahead, northwesterly winds, which are relatively dry and cool, will start prevailing over the region. These winds will reduce moisture levels in the atmosphere, leading to a decrease in fog conditions. Temperatures will begin to rise gradually over the next two to three days, though the increase will not be sharp, and summer-like conditions will return progressively," he added.

Speaker reviews arrangements for upcoming Budget Session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta reviewed the arrangements for the upcoming Budget Session, emphasising the need for informed debate, measured conduct, and meaningful interventions that serve the public interest.

The session, scheduled from March 23 to 25, 2026, is expected to uphold the dignity of the House and set a high standard for deliberations. "Let's make this session a reflection of our finest parliamentary traditions," he said, urging members to contribute constructively.

Speaker Vijender Gupta conducted a thorough review of the Assembly's readiness, stressing coordinated efforts across teams. Legislative, security, and technical teams are fully synchronised, and



systems are in place. To enhance tech-enabled functioning, tablets are being provided to members for seamless access to documents and proceedings, ensuring efficient conduct of business.

To reinforce the Assembly's solemn and national character, the Speaker has directed that 'Vande Mataram' be performed live by an eminent singer at the start of each sitting, with a simultaneous display on screens in the

House. This is intended to set a tone of national spirit and reflection.

Further strengthening this initiative, the full rendition of 'Vande Mataram' will be played live at the commencement of proceedings and displayed across screens within the House, creating a shared moment of national spirit and collective reflection at the outset of each sitting.

In a significant first-of-its-kind initiative, the Delhi Legislative Assembly will roll out 'Vidhan Sathi', an in-house AI-enabled chatbot designed to function as a dedicated legislative research assistant for members. The platform will provide structured, data-backed responses, assist in the analysis of Bills, Acts, and policy matters, and enable Members to engage with legislative business with greater clarity and depth.

Delhi's first International Film Festival to begin on March 25

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Government Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra on Saturday announced the organisation of Delhi's first International Film Festival, Delhi (IFFD) 2026. He stated that the Delhi Government and the Delhi Tourism Department, under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, will organise the festival from March 25 to 31 at Bharat Mandapam.

Mishra said that Delhi has three primary objectives. Counting on the objectives, the minister said the first is to advance the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi regarding the orange economy and creators economy by developing Delhi as a hub for live entertainment. The festival aims to provide a global platform to young talents associated with theatre, art, direction, camera, animation, AI and



other creative fields, enabling their work to be seen worldwide.

The second objective is to showcase Delhi's world-class infrastructure for hosting global events — developed during the Prime Minister's tenure — including Bharat Mandapam, Yashobhoomi, Kartavya Path, the National War Memorial, the new Parliament building, and the

Prime Minister's Museum.

The third key objective of the festival is to establish Delhi as a preferred destination for film shooting.

Mishra stated that the chief minister has also extended her best wishes for the event. She described IFFD as a cinema festival that promotes creativity, creates opportunities, and firmly establishes Delhi on

the global cultural map.

The minister further informed that more than 2,000 entries have been received from countries around the world for this festival. Out of these, 140 films have been selected for screening for cinema lovers.

Along with international films, the festival will showcase the diversity of India through selected films from

Tamil, Telugu, Gujarati, Marathi, Bhojpuri, Punjabi, Haryanvi, North-Eastern and Bengali cinema.

Additionally, some major Bollywood films will also be screened. Notably, the screening of "Dhurandhar 2" will be a major attraction of the festival.

Mishra said that over the past year, the Delhi Government and Delhi Tourism have made several significant efforts to promote art, culture and tourism in the Capital.

These include a grand drone show at India Gate during Diwali, large-scale arrangements for Chhath Puja and Kanwar Yatra, as well as celebrations of Teej. Initiatives such as Bhajan Clubbing in Delhi University have also been undertaken to connect the younger generation with culture and tradition. Shortly a Bhajan clubbing at JNU will also be organised.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Hem Lata W/o Vishal Manocha Resident of CM-1/1305, Supertech Capetown, Sector-74, Noida, UP-201301., have changed my name from Hem Lata to Vidhi Manocha. Henceforth, I would be known by the name of Vidhi Manocha for all future purposes

PD(573)C

I, No.14834918K HsVr Peri Ramachandra Murthy, R/o- Quarter No. P246 A4 Sagar Pur, Gali No. 2, Delhi Cantt, declare that Peri Lasritha is my daughter, in her School records, her D.O.B. is erroneously recorded as 03/02/2016, whereas her correct D.O.B. is 03/02/2017 which may be amended accordingly.

PD(575)C

I, Jucy Yadav, Wife of- JC-781461N Nb/Sub Ashok Kumar, R/o- Harinagar Charaiya, PO- Bhatrandha, Ward No.1, Dist- Madhepura, Bihar- 852124, have changed my name from Jucy Yadav to Jucy Kumari, vide affidavit dated 21/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(574)C

PD(576)C

LOST & FOUND

To be known to all that Mr. Ramneek Hans S/o Late Mr. Ved Prakash Hans, Mr. Subhash Hans S/o Late Mr. Kishan Chand and I, Anil Hans S/o Late Mr. Arjun Dev Hans all Residents of House No. A-171, Ashok Vihar, Phase-I, Delhi, are the joint and absolute owners of A-171, Ashok Vihar, Phase-I, Delhi-110052. That we have lost the original DDA Possession Letter, Original Form C, Original Bid Form and Payment Challans, Original Building Plan Sanction Letter and other relevant documents and correspondences issued by DDA while getting the same photocopied. That same are not traceable inspite of our best efforts. An NCR in this effect has been lodged Vide LR No. -176554/2026 dated 19-03-2026. Finder Contact: 9650406611

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, रायगढ़ (छगण0)

क्रमांक 10995/ न.पा.नि. / 2026 रायगढ़ दिनांक 20/3/26.

॥ ई-प्रोक्चोरमेन्ट निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना ॥

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PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Ashok Batra S/o Late Sant Ram Batra and Praveen Batra W/o Ashok Batra, R/o C-57A, Shiv Vihar, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, hereby disown our son Manish Batra from all our movable and immovable properties. We have severed all relations with him. Any person dealing with him shall do so at their own risk. We shall not be responsible for his acts.

Deponents
Ashok Batra
Praveen Batra

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is informed to the general public that my clients Dal Chand S/o Ram Narayan and Santosh W/o Dal Chand, R/o H.No. F-2/30, Sultanpuri, Delhi-110086, have disowned their Son Vikas Kumar and daughter-in-law Neha W/o Vikas Kumar from all their movable/immovable properties and severed all their relations both legal & social with them due to disrespectful behavior. Any person dealing with them shall be doing so at his/her own risk, and my clients shall not be responsible for the same.

Sanjeev Dwivedi (Advocate)
48, Gaganand Block, Tis Hazari Courts, ND-54

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Lalan Singh who is Purchasing of Plot No. 76B, area measuring 28 Sq. Yards, part of Kharsa No. 626, situated in the area of Village Nawada, colony known as Mohan Garden, in Block-N, New Delhi-110059, from Smt. Anita Devi who owned the said Property vide GPA ATS and Will dated 07/08/2000 duly attested with the Notary Public Delhi now Shri Lalan Singh intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD That, Khatori issued by concerned Patwari in favour of Mr. Raju in respect of pieces of land and Mutation/House Tax issued by Municipal Corporation in favour of Mrs. Anita Devi in respect of the said property, has been lost/misplaced/not available. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucem Legal LLP
N-161, Ground Floor, Salra Tower, Gautam Nagar
Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049
Contact 2 011-40046316 & 41667327

MCD expedites setting up construction and demolition plant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has stepped up efforts to expedite the setting up of the Tekhband construction and demolition

(C&D) waste processing plant to tackle the issue of debris in the city. December 2026 has been set as the deadline for its construction.

Officials said that the upcoming facility near Okhla will add 1,000 metric tonnes per day to the existing processing capacity,

which currently stands at around 5,000 metric tonnes, even as Delhi generates 7,000 metric tonnes of C&D waste, officials said.

Officials said that many times the shortfall has led to frequent accumulation of debris across the Capital, contributing to air pollution.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Shamim Ahmed is the owner of a Flat (Without Roof Rights) on First Floor Built on Plot No. 5-A, Area 58.53 Sq. Mtrs Out of Kharsa No. 34, Situated in the Everest & Panchvati Village-Mahima Sarai Alias Kood Pargana Loni Tehsil & Distt. Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh. Same is Owned by Sale Deed Dated 28.03.2022 Document No. 2968 executed by Mrs. Ram Rati & Mr. Pawan Gang in Favor of Mr. Shamim Ahmed that Mr. Shamim Ahmed took Financial Facility From Hinduja Housing Finance Ltd for Purchasing this Property that this Sale Deed has been lost that Mr. Shamim Ahmed informed to Delhi Police on dated 19.03.2026 LAR No. 175911/2026, All Persons are hereby informed that if anybody has found this documents or Any Person, Corporation, company, financial institution & others has any claim/charge/interest/title in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Rohit Kumar Advocate
Medhawi Enforcement & Legal Service
Office No 314, Third Floor, Rishabh Cloude 9, Sector-01 Vaishali Ghaziabad U.P. Mob no: 7306061626, 9818171626, Email: medhawienforcement@gmail.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Ankur Kumar is the owner of a Residential Plot Area admeasuring 68 Sq. Yards i.e. 58.86 Sq. Meters, Related Kharsa No. 292/786, Situated at Village Kamalpur (Main Meerut Garh Road after the Black River Near Hasanpur Kadirji), Pargana, Tehsil & District Meerut, Uttar Pradesh. Same is Owned by Sale Deed Dated 28.12.2023 Document No. 14341 executed by Mr. Afroz Alam S/o. Mr. Sartaj Ahamed in favour of (1) Mr. Naushad Alam S/o. Mohd. Yameen and (2) Mr. Abdul Rahim S/o. Mr. Jafid Ali that the both Sale Deeds has been lost that Mr. Ankur Kumar informed to U.P Police on dated 31.10.2025, That Mr. Ankur Kumar & Mrs. Pooja Kansal are Mortgaging this property with Griham Housing Finance Ltd. All Persons are hereby informed that if anybody has found these documents or Any Person, Corporation, company, financial institution & others has any claim/charge/interest/title in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Rohit Kumar Advocate
Medhawi Enforcement & Legal Service
Office No 314, Third Floor, Rishabh Cloude 9, Sector-01 Vaishali Ghaziabad U.P. Mob no: 7306061626, 9818171626, Email: medhawienforcement@gmail.com

LOST & FOUND

To be known to all That Mrs. Meena Gulati Wife of Mr. Madan Mohan Gulati and I, Madan Mohan Gulati Son of Mr. Prakash Chand Gulati Both residents of Flat No.124-C, Block-CD, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, are the joint and absolute owners of CD-124-C, Second Floor, Pitampura, Delhi-110034. That we have lost the Notary Files of all previous Chains, and other relevant documents and correspondences in respect of the above said property, while getting the same photocopied. That same are not traceable inspite of our best efforts. An NCR in this effect has been lodged vide LR No. 176834/2026 dated 19-03-2026 Finder Contact: 9540089979

Govt approves ₹3,700 crore dues for Peripheral Expressways

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Rekha Gupta Government in Delhi on Saturday approved the payment of its pending share for land acquisition related to the Eastern and Western Peripheral Expressways.

While the eastern peripheral expressway envisages signal-free connectivity between Ghaziabad, Faridabad, Gautam Budh Nagar (Greater Noida) and Palwal, the western Peripheral expressway connects Kundli to Palwal via Manesar in Haryana. Both are 135 km each.

Approving the payment of its share for land acquisition regarding Peripheral Expressways, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the decision would help ease congestion caused by heavy vehicles and bring down pollution levels in the city. These expressways were designed to divert non-destined traffic—especially trucks—away from Delhi, thereby reducing pres-

sure on city roads.

Earlier, the AAP Government in Delhi had opposed the Centre's demand to pay over ₹3,500 crore spent on acquiring land for the Eastern and Western Peripheral Expressways. In an affidavit in the Supreme Court, the Delhi Government had stated that the state had already paid ₹700 crore and did not want to shell out more.

Taking a swipe at the previous Government, the Chief Minister alleged that the project had suffered due to a lack of seriousness and political differences with the Centre, which led to deliberate delays in clearing the dues, ultimately harming Delhi's interests.

Sharing details, the chief minister said the Cabinet recently approved a proposal by the Public Works Department to clear the outstanding amount in a phased manner. As part of this plan, ₹500 crore will be released in the financial year 2025-26 from the revised budget estimates to the Union



Government or the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI). The remaining ₹3,203.33 crore will be paid in installments in the coming years, depending on budgetary provisions.

According to the Chief Minister, the expressways,

which became operational in 2018, have effectively created a protective traffic ring around Delhi through Haryana and Uttar Pradesh.

She said the payment would resolve long-pending interstate financial issues and improve coordination with

the Centre for future infrastructure projects. The project has already contributed to reduced travel time and has played a key role in improving Delhi's air quality by limiting the entry of heavy diesel vehicles into the city.

Taking a dig at the previous

AAP government, the Chief Minister said the previous administration, accusing it of neglecting Delhi's long-term development. She said the earlier government was more focused on creating unnecessary disputes with the Centre rather than improving infra-

WHY PERIPHERAL EXPRESSWAYS MATTER FOR DELHI

New Delhi: The Eastern Peripheral Expressway (EPE) and Western Peripheral Expressway (WPE) together form a 'smart ring road' around Delhi. Each stretches about 135 km and has six lanes, designed to keep lakhs of heavy and commercial vehicles from entering the city if they are merely passing through. This has eased unnecessary pressure on Delhi's roads, reduced the number of diesel vehicles entering the capital, and helped lower pollution levels. It has also led to smoother traffic flow and significant time savings for commuters.

As a result, congestion on

key routes such as Ring Road, Outer Ring Road, and major national highways like NH-44 and NH-48 has reduced, saving both time and fuel for daily commuters. Importantly, these expressways connect major regions in Haryana—Kundli, Manesar, and Palwal—and in Uttar Pradesh—Ghaziabad, Gautam Buddh Nagar, and Baghpat, making them a crucial backbone for logistics and trade in North India. The project is also regarded as India's first 'smart and green' expressway, featuring solar energy use and drip irrigation systems to promote greenery along the route.

structure. According to her, the delay in releasing funds had stalled progress for years. With the current decision, she asserted, infrastructure projects in Delhi will no longer suffer due to financial constraints or political deadlock. The Chief Minister

expressed confidence that the step would help the city move faster towards becoming a 'smart and pollution-free' capital. She reiterated that her government is committed to working in coordination with the Centre to fast-track development.



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta met Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday and discussed the national capital's all-around development. "I had the privilege of a heartfelt meeting with the Honourable Prime Minister Narendra Modi, during which I received his invaluable guidance. His visionary leadership and special affection for Delhi always fill us with fresh energy and inspiration," the chief minister said in a post on X. The BJP leader said that during the meeting, detailed discussions on Delhi's all-around development were held, including strengthening infrastructure and commitment to fulfilling the people's aspirations. "With the able guidance and continuous support of the prime minister, we are fully committed to taking Delhi to new heights of progress, prosperity, and good governance," she added. She also thanked the prime minister for his constant inspiration and for giving his valuable time.

PIONEER PHOTO

People throng mosques for Eid prayers across Capital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

People thronged mosques across the national capital for namaz on Eid al-Fitr on Saturday, embracing the spirit of unity and devotion, as a blanket of fog added an unusual charm to the celebrations. The Delhi Police said security was stepped up across the city to maintain law and order and ensure a peaceful Eid.

A soft haze hung over several parts of the city, with mosque domes and minarets appearing partially veiled, creating a striking visual. A sense of celebration was palpable as people exchanged greetings after the namaz.



People from the Muslim community offer prayers on the occasion of Eid Al-Fitr, at Jama Masjid in New Delhi

PTI

Mufti Mukarram Ahmed, the Shahi Imam at Jama Masjid, called it a day of joy and togetherness. "This is the festival of Eid, the 'Meethi Eid'. I appeal to people across the country to stand

together in both happiness and sorrow, promote love and harmony, and help one another," he said. Ahmed said humanity remains the strongest bond, and no religion advocates conflict.

PWD launches QR code boards on roads for public feedback

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a move aimed at citizen participation, the Public Works Department (PWD) has introduced QR/Bar code-enabled display boards on roads undergoing strengthening and recarpeting. The move will not only provide information but also enable citizens to share their feedback directly.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the initiative seeks to transform how people engage with public infrastructure projects by providing easy access to



key information while also creating a direct channel for feedback.

As per the new directive, within 7 days of completion of any road work, display boards will be installed at prominent public locations such as bus

queue shelters, major intersections, and high footfall areas to ensure visibility and accessibility.

"Transparency is not just about sharing information; it is about listening to the people. With this initiative, citizens will not only know the details of road works but will also be able to give their feedback directly," the Public Works Department (PWD) minister said.

"These will be placed at prominent public locations such as bus queue shelters, major intersections, and other high footfall areas to ensure visibility," Verma said.

Eid prayers offered in Uttam Nagar under heavy security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Muslims offered Eid-ul-Fitr prayers in west Delhi's Uttam Nagar on Saturday under heavy security, with the area witnessing a subdued celebration days after a localised clash left a man dead and triggered tensions.

A video circulating on social media shows two men carrying a bag filled with flower petals and showering them on police and Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel, while someone in the background is heard saying, "The cops gave full support."

Another person can also be heard saying, "They did a fantastic job."

Meanwhile, police detained

around 95 people for raising provocative slogans and trying to disturb law and order.

A heavy deployment of Delhi Police and paramilitary personnel is in place across Hastal village and nearby areas, with barricades set up at key entry and exit points and strict identity checks being carried out, police said.

Only residents are being allowed access to certain stretches after verification, while the movement of outsiders is restricted. Police teams also conducted regular foot patrols and are monitoring rooftops, narrow lanes and other sensitive pockets through CCTV cameras to prevent any untoward incident.



Police personnel stand guard as people arrive to offer prayers on the occasion of Eid al-Fitr at Uttam Nagar in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Dwarka) Kushal Pal Singh said the situation is calm. "The environment here is peaceful. People offered namaz without any distur-

bance. We have maintained tight security in the area and are continuing routine patrols and picketing," he said, urging people not to believe rumours on social media.



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IN FOCUS



A yak walks through a snow-covered area, at Sandakphu area in Darjeeling district, West Bengal on Saturday

PTI

Shah to introduce bill for umbrella law on CAPFs in RS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will introduce in the Rajya Sabha on Monday an “umbrella law” for Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) to regulate recruitment, deputation, promotion and other conditions of services of their officers, according to the List of Business issued by the House.

All the CAPFs — CRPF, BSF, ITBP and SSB — are governed by their respective Acts. The rules under these Acts govern the recruitment and conditions of service of Group A General Duty Officers and other officers and members in the CAPFs.

The Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026, provides that for the purposes of appointment of officers from the Indian Police Service in CAPFs, 50 per cent of the posts will be filled by depu-

tation in the rank of Inspector General and a minimum of 67 per cent of the posts will be filled by deputation in the rank of Additional Director General.

The posts in the ranks of Special Director General and Director General shall be filled by deputation only, it proposes. The proposed legislation comes after the Supreme Court, in October last year, dismissed the Centre's plea seeking a review of its 2025 verdict that directed that IPS officers' deputation in the CAPFs be reduced and asked for a cadre review to be carried out in six months.

“In view of expanding functional and operational requirements, the distinct organisational structure of these Forces have evolved over a period of time. In recent years, due to the absence of an umbrella law, regulatory provisions have evolved in a fragmented manner, resulting in several



litigations on service-related matters, leading to some functional and administrative difficulties,” the objectives of the bill state.

The bill seeks to regulate the recruitment, deputation, promotion and other conditions of services of Group A General Duty Officers and other officers appointed in these Central Armed Police Forces, the Objectives of the bill circulated among Rajya Sabha members said.

opportunities within CAPFs inevitably carries implications not only for institutional morale but also for the operational effectiveness of forces responsible for protecting India's internal stability and border security,” the group said in a press statement on Friday.

The proposed law states that under Article 312 of the Constitution, the Indian Police Service is an All India Service and the officers of the Service are posted in the Union and the States.

“Historically, Indian Police Service officers are an integral and important part of the Central Armed Police Forces, who have been serving on deputation along with officers and members of these Forces,” the Objectives of the Bill state.

The CAPFs perform functions relating to national security and anti-insurgency in close coordination with the State authorities, it said.

“Therefore, in the interest of maintaining Centre-State relations by ensuring close coordination between the Union and the States for effective operational functioning, it is essential to maintain the existing system of deputation of the Indian Police Service Officers in the Central Armed Police Forces,” the document said.

The listed objectives of the proposed law said that the CAPFs are governed by the respective Acts of Parliament.

It said that, considering the nature and purposes of the CAPFs and to avoid unnecessary litigations, there is a need to lay down an umbrella law to regulate the recruitment, deputation, promotion and other conditions of services of Group A General Duty Officers and other officers appointed in these Central Armed Police Forces and other rules regarding these Forces.

Navy set to commission frontline stealth frigate Taragiri

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indigenous stealth frigate ‘Taragiri’, endowed with the cutting-edge weapon suite including supersonic missiles, is set to be commissioned into the Indian Navy on April 3, officials said on Saturday.

The ceremony in Visakhapatnam is scheduled to be presided over by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, and it will serve as a powerful testament to the nation's journey toward becoming a completely self-reliant naval power, they said.

As the fourth potent platform of the Project 17A class, ‘Taragiri’ is not merely a ship; it is a 6,670-tonne embodiment of the ‘Make in India’ spirit and the sophisticated engineering capabilities of our indigenous shipyards, a Navy spokesperson said.



Indian Naval Ship (INS) Taragiri before its commissioning ceremony at Visakhapatnam

PTI

The fourth ship of Nilgiri-class (Project 17A) and the third one built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilding Ltd (MDL), ‘Taragiri’ (Yard 12653), was delivered to the Navy on November 28 last year at MDL, Mumbai, marking a major milestone in achieving self-reliance in warship design and construction.

This state-of-the-art frigate reflects a “quantum leap” in naval design, stealth, fire-

power, automation and survivability, and is a symbol of ‘aatmanirbharta’ in warship building, the Navy had then said. “In a ceremony that will mark a defining moment for India's maritime sovereignty, the Navy is preparing to commission its latest stealth frigate, ‘Taragiri’ (F41), on April 3,” the spokesperson said.

Driven by a Combined Diesel or Gas (CODOG) propulsion plant, ‘Taragiri’ is

designed for “high speed, high endurance versatility and multi-dimensional maritime operations,” the Navy said.

“The ship's weapon suite is world-class, featuring supersonic surface-to-surface missiles, medium range surface-to-air missiles, and a specialised anti-submarine warfare suite,” the spokesperson added.

These systems are seamlessly integrated through a state-of-the-art Combat Management System, ensuring that the crew can “respond to threats with split-second precision,” the official said.

Built by MDL, Mumbai, this frigate represents a “generational leap” over earlier designs, offering a sleeker form and a significantly reduced radar cross-section that allows it to operate with lethal stealth, the Navy said.

With indigenous content

exceeding 75 per cent, the ship highlights the maturity of a domestic industrial ecosystem that now spans over 200 Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), and contributing to the Government's Aatmanirbharta initiative, supports thousands of Indian jobs, the officials said.

Beyond its role as a “premier hunter of the seas”, ‘Taragiri’ is built for the complexities of modern diplomacy and humanitarian crises.

Its “flexible mission profile” makes it ideal for everything from high-intensity combat to humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR), the Navy said.

“The Indian Navy continues to grow as a combat-ready, cohesive, credible, Aatmanirbhara force, safeguarding the seas for a ‘Viksit, Samridha Bharat’ guarded by ships designed by Indians, built by Indians and operated by Indians.

Chakankar's resignation forwarded to CM Fadnavis: Sunetra Pawar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

NCP chief and Maharashtra deputy CM Sunetra Pawar on Saturday said she has forwarded Rupali Chakankar's resignation as State women's commission chairperson to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis for acceptance.

Chakankar, a leader of the Nationalist Congress Party, on Friday tendered her resignation after facing flak from Opposition parties over her association with rape-accused ‘godman’ Ashok Kharat.

Following a meeting with CM Fadnavis, who asked her to step down, she handed the resignation letter personally to Sunetra Pawar late in the evening.

“Chakankar has tendered her resignation, considering the current circumstances and ongoing investigation. To



ensure that the probe is conducted in a fair and transparent manner, I have forwarded her resignation to the Chief Minister for further process,” Pawar said in a statement.

Appointed as chairperson of the Maharashtra State Women's Commission first in October 2021, Chakankar was given another three-year term in 2024.

Kharat, who heads a temple trust at Sinnar and had several political leaders visit him over the years, was

arrested by Nashik Police on Wednesday for allegedly repeatedly sexually assaulting a woman.

As per the complainant, he called her to his office sometime in 2022 after her marriage, claiming that his astrological predictions pointed to a threat to her husband's life and she needed to perform certain rituals to ward it off. He then gave her a sedative-laced drink and raped her, the woman alleged, claiming that he raped her multiple times over the next three years.

Cow vigilante run over by truck, protests in Mathura

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mathura

A cow vigilante popularly known as ‘Farsa wale Baba’ was killed after he was struck by a truck on a highway near the Haryana border early Saturday, when he, along with his aides, stopped another vehicle on suspicion of cattle smuggling, officials said.

The incident triggered violent protests and a traffic blockade on the day when President Droupadi Murmu was visiting the district. Angry locals blocked the national highway, leading to traffic snarls stretching several kilometres.

Supporters of Chandrashekhar, who was known as ‘Farsa wale Baba’, alleged he was run over by cattle smugglers when he was trying to stop a truck carrying cattle near the Kotvan border area. Authorities rejected the claim and claimed the accident occurred due to poor visibility.

District Magistrate Chandra Prakash Singh said the incident occurred around 4 am when the victim, along with his followers, stopped a Nagaland-registered contain-



People stage a protest after a man popularly known as ‘Farsa wale Baba’ died under suspicious circumstances on a highway near the Haryana border, in the Chaumuhan area of Mathura on Saturday

PTI

er on suspicion that it was carrying cattle near the Kosi Kalan area. The vehicle was found to be carrying grocery items such as soap, phenyl and shampoo.

He said that amid dense fog, a Rajasthan-registered truck carrying wire rammed into them from behind, leading to Chandrashekhar's death on the spot. The truck driver was injured, and the vehicle was damaged.

According to videos circulating on social media, protesters allegedly vandalised

police and administrative vehicles when authorities attempted to clear the road.

The police later resorted to mild force to disperse the crowd.

Senior Superintendent of Police Shlok Kumar said some anti-social elements tried to disturb the situation, prompting police action.

Four to five people have been detained for questioning, he said, adding that the situation was under control with traffic restored. Heavy police deployment has been

made in the area, he added. The police said Chandrashekhar's body was taken by followers to his gaushala (cow shelter) in Ajanokh village for the last rites. A post-mortem will be conducted if the family or followers request it in writing.

Earlier in the day, Murmu prayed at the Danghati Temple in Govardhan, where she participated in the aarti of Giriraj Ji Maharaj and performed Govardhan Parikrama as part of her three-day Uttar Pradesh visit.

West Asia crisis hits rice exports from MP districts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhopal

Export of basmati and boiled non-basmati rice from Madhya Pradesh to several countries has been severely impacted by the West Asia crisis, stakeholders in the sector said on Saturday.

Basmati rice from Raisen and boiled non-basmati rice from Balaghat have a distinct identity and are exported to many foreign countries, including the Gulf, they pointed out.

“Basmati rice destined for export from Raisen district is stuck in ports, factories and warehouses. Freight rates have increased by 30 per cent, and there is a shortage of containers. Exporters are also facing backlog of goods at ports. All this has made it difficult to fulfil orders on time,” Ajay Bhalotia, All India Rice Exporters Association general secretary, said.

More than two dozen rice factories operate in Mandideep, Satapur, Obedullaganj, Raisen, Bareilly, Udayapura, and Umraoganj areas of Raisen district, with high-quality basmati rice making its way to markets in Iran, Iraq,



Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Dubai, etc, he said.

Halt in exports due to the Iran war has temporarily closed down some rice units in the district, leaving the once-thriving sector in trouble, Bhalotia added.

“The price of Pusa Basmati rice has fallen by Rs 300-500 per quintal. This has disrupted and reduced the arrival of paddy and raw materials, weakening the supply chain. It has distressed farmers. If the war continues for a long time, small and medium-sized industries will be particularly affected,” said Raisen Rice Factory operator Manoj Soni.

The West Asia crisis has hit

the district's economy, and even containers are now in short supply, Rajiv Agarwal, former president of the Association of All Industries, said.

“Earlier, a container used to be available here for USD 2,500. Now, it is not easily available even for USD 3,200. The increase in freight has directly increased the cost of exports. Moreover, goods that have already been shipped from here are stuck at ports. It is affecting the payment cycle and increasing pressure on the working capital of industries,” Agarwal said.

Anil Jain, a wholesale rice trader, said the arrival of paddy in the market

has started decreasing, and farmers have only a few days' stock.

A district official claimed high-quality Pusa rice is cultivated in Raisen, which is exported with Haryana's GI (geographical indication) tag.

Raisen district cultivates paddy on approximately 3.45 lakh hectares and produces over 6 lakh tonnes of rice, he informed.

Similar is the situation with boiled non-basmati rice grown in abundance in Balaghat, sector stakeholders said.

“Local millers used to export large quantities of this rice from Balaghat, Warasivani, Katangi, and surrounding areas. Before the war, approximately 500 tonnes of rice were exported daily, but this has been severely affected by the current Gulf crisis. Rice exports to East African countries have virtually ceased, while limited exports to West Africa continue,” prominent industrialist Palash Somani contended.

The significant increase in sea freight has made the trade even more unprofitable, resulting in financial losses for millers, he added.

FROM PAGE - 1

Senior BJD leader's house attacked, Patnaik seeks CM's intervention

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhubaneswar

BJD chief Naveen Patnaik on Saturday sought Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi's intervention to restore law and order following an attack on the residence of a senior BJD leader and former minister, police said.

According to a complaint lodged at the Capital Police Station, security staff of BJD leader Pratap Jena alleged that around 15 miscreants attacked his residence on Friday night and used abusive language.

According to the complaint, the attackers were armed with iron rods, a knife and a gun, and attempted to terrorise the security personnel.

On Friday morning, the party had



issued a notice, signed by Jena in his capacity as vice-president (headquarters), suspending 10 members of the party's youth and student wings on charges of anti-party activities.

Speaking to reporters after the attack on his house, Jena alleged that some suspended members of the party's youth and student wings

created a ruckus outside his residence.

In a post on X, Patnaik said, “I strongly condemn the armed attack that took place last night on the residence of Pratap Jena, senior leader of the Biju Janata Dal and former minister. Those who insulted democracy with the power of money in the Rajya Sabha elections — their goons carried out this act of violence. This is not two separate incidents but a blatant example of misrule and lack of lawlessness.”

Patnaik demanded that immediate action be taken in this matter and the culprits arrested. “I urge the chief minister to intervene to restore the law and order situation that has deteriorated in the state,” he said.

Nuclear site in Iran targeted

IAEA Director-General Rafael Grossi reiterated the need for military restraint to prevent any nuclear accidents.

Russia condemned the strike, calling it a clear breach of international law, with Foreign Ministry spokeswoman Maria Zakharova labeling the attack as “illegal and provocative.” This attack follows previous strikes on Natanz during conflicts in 2025. Analysts warn that the site remains a high-priority target amid ongoing tensions in the region.

Mamata slams BJP over voter rights

She said her Government had approached the Calcutta High Court and the Supreme Court of India, expressing hope that people's rights will be protected.

Her remarks come amid an ongoing confrontation between the State Government and the Election Commission of India over

the revision of electoral rolls, which the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) claims has led to exclusion of legitimate voters.

Banerjee also accused the Union Government of promoting communal narratives for political gain and alleged that an undeclared President's Rule was being imposed in the State.

The BJP has made illegal immigration a central campaign issue, accusing the State Government of enabling infiltration from Bangladesh to consolidate its minority vote base.

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, who also addressed the gathering, said the party would defend Bengal's communal harmony. “Attempts to divide communities will fail,” he said. Elections to the 294-member West Bengal Assembly will be held in two phases on April 23 and April 29, with counting scheduled for May 4.

LPG boost for hotels, canteens

Earlier, the Government had offered an additional 10 per cent, subject to states expedit-

ing PNG projects.

OMCs are to register such customers and keep a record of the sector they operate in the end-use of LPG and annual weight requirement of LPG of that customer in respective database(s).

The letter further stated that no fuel shortages have been reported at retail outlets, and the public has been advised against panic buying. Natural gas supplies to priority segments, including domestic PNG and CNG transport, are being fully maintained, while industrial consumers are receiving about 80 per cent of their usual supply.

Meanwhile, refiners in India have started contemplating buying Iranian oil after US on Saturday removed sanctions on Iranian oil at sea. Refiners are awaiting Government directions and clarity from Washington on details such as payment terms etc.

On Friday, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent permitted the sale of Iranian oil currently stranded at sea, reversing Washington's longstanding policy. Explaining the move, Bessent said the step is intended to inject additional supply into global markets.



Safety of Indians living in UAE is a priority: Envoy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The UAE has assured India that the safety of Indians living in the Gulf country is its “priority”, stressing that they are protected and treated like family, especially amid the ongoing conflict in West Asia which has seen the emirate facing attacks from Iran.

UAE Ambassador to India Abdulnasser Alshaali also hailed India’s move to co-sponsor a UN resolution that condemned Iran’s attacks against Gulf countries, saying it was a statement of principle from a country that the UAE considers a strategic partner and friend, at a moment when it mattered most. The UAE will remember that India was among those “who stood with us first”, he said.

“The safety of Indian nationals in the UAE is a priority. They are protected and are treated as family, including the 200 nationalities living in the country in peace and harmony,” Alshaali told PTI Videos.

He said that UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan visited five injured civilians in the hospital: two Emiratis, one Indian, one Sudanese and one Iranian. He said: “They are all our responsibility.”



UAE Ambassador to India Abdulnasser Alshaali REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

“Four million Indians live in the UAE; they are not a statistic. They are the son from Kerala sending money home each month so his mother can pay her medical bills, the engineer from Hyderabad building infrastructure that will stand for a century, the teacher from Tamil Nadu shaping the futures of Emirati children,” he said.

In 2024, the UAE was the second-largest source of remittances to India, totalling USD 21.6 billion.

“Those four million Indians represent families in every state of India whose livelihoods depend on a stable and secure UAE. Their safety is a personal responsibility that this country’s leadership carries every day,” he said. “What I would say to Indian families is this: the UAE’s commitment to protecting the people who have built their lives here is absolute.”

On Iranian attacks, Alshaali

said the UAE’s integrated air defence systems have intercepted a vast majority of incoming threats and the country “remains safe, secure, and well-protected”.

He said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi called the UAE President before any resolution was drafted, before any multilateral statement and before any formal diplomatic process had begun.

“That call was received as an act of brotherhood. India then co-sponsored UN Security Council Resolution 2817—a statement of principle from a country that the UAE considers a strategic partner and friend, at a moment it mattered most. The UAE will remember who stood with us. India was among those who stood with us first,” he said.

The UN Security Council Resolution 2817, co-sponsored by India, sent a “clear and unified message that

the international community will not tolerate attacks on our sovereignty or the deliberate targeting of civilians and critical infrastructure”, he said.

When asked about the damage inflicted by Iran, Alshaali said Tehran launched a “sustained, unprovoked, and aggressive assault” against the Gulf countries.

“As of March 20, the UAE alone has faced 338 ballistic missiles, 15 cruise missiles, and more than 1,740 drones, more than all other targeted countries combined,” he said, adding that Iranian munitions have struck residential neighbourhoods, commercial districts and civilian infrastructure.

Giving details of the casualties, he said six persons have been killed and 158 injured.

“These are not military casualties — these are civilians. The UAE condemns Iran’s egregious aggression in the strongest possible terms,” he said.

Alshaali said the UAE has not stopped functioning for a single day. “Schools remain open, hospitals are operating, and supply chains are intact. More than 10 million citizens, residents, and visitors have continued their daily lives despite Iran’s actions,” he said.

Rijiju calls Tamil Nadu a very interesting society

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The people of Tamil Nadu are temperamentally very scientific, good in technical education and science but love films, movie stars and have built a cult-kind of respect and stature for actors, Union Minister Kiren Rijiju said on Saturday.

Without mentioning anyone, the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs said the people of the state were a “very interesting society.”

“Tamil people are so talented, they can do wonders if they get good governance,” the minister told reporters here.

The BJP leader, who was in the city and attended a private function and addressed law students, said ground reports from the state indicated that there was “discontentment” among the people and that the “anti-incumbency factor is unprecedented.”



“There’s a huge undercurrent anti-incumbency factor in Tamil Nadu. So, because of that the NDA will come to power. People are saying that they are unhappy with the DMK Government. So, NDA will form the Government in Tamil Nadu. This is the ground situation reports indicate,” he said.

To a question, Rijiju replied “Tamil people are temperamentally very scientific, good in technical education, science, and at the same time love films and film stars. And they built a cult-kind of respect and stature for film stars. A very interesting society.”

Tamils were so talented that they would create wonders if they were provided good governance, he added.

On the impact of the Gulf war on India, he said though the impact was all over the world, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Centre “very efficiently managed the economy.”

275 former judges, armed forces veterans slam USCIRF report on RSS ban call

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 275 former judges, civil servants and armed forces veterans have criticised a recent report by the United States Commission on International Religious Freedom (USCIRF), which recommended a ban on the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). They called the report “highly motivated”, reflecting “intellectual bankruptcy and deranged calculations”.

In a joint statement issued on Saturday, they urged the US Government to carry out a strict background check of all the contributors to this “highly prejudiced and untenable report” in USCIRF, alleging vested interests aimed at vitiating their goodwill with the people of Bharat.

“USCIRF’s recommendation to freeze assets, restrict



ed movement of Bharatiya citizens and placing restrictions on those associated with RSS is highly motivated, and displays intellectual bankruptcy and deranged conclusions,” the signatories said in a joint statement.

“All six commissioners of USCIRF are appointed by US Government and funded by American Taxpayers through the US Congress. We call upon the US Government to carry out a strict background

check of all the contributors to this report in USCIRF.

“It will be an eye opener to the tax payers of US, whose funds are being used by USCIRF to produce highly prejudiced and untenable reports to promote hidden agenda of some anti-Bharat vested interests to vitiate their goodwill with the people of Bharat,” they added.

The statement also raised concerns over what it termed

USCIRF’s recurring tendency to portray Indian institutions and socio-cultural organisations such as the RSS in a negative light without adequate context. “It shows the recurring tendency of USCIRF to portray Indian state institutions and socio-cultural organisations such as the RSS in an overw-helmingly negative aspects, often without proper macro-level evidence.

“It raises legitimate concerns about analytical balance. The RSS, with its extensive grassroots presence and contributions to social service and nation-building, may well be subject to critique, but such critique must be grounded in verifiable evidence and contextual understanding, not only on broad generalisations,” it said.

They emphasised that India, as the world’s largest democracy with a robust

judicial system and institutional oversight, provides limited scope for violations of religious rights to go undressed.

“Bharat is the largest democracy of the world. Given the robust, time tested judicial system, vibrant democratic institutions and Parliamentary oversight, there’s very less scope for individuals or organizations to go scot-free after violating someone’s religious rights,” the signatories added.

The signatories lauded the role of the RSS in society, stating that it has been working in various fields not only in India but also abroad, especially during times of natural disasters, while supporting vulnerable sections of society.

Having been founded in 1925 during the struggle for independence from British occupation, RSS is committed to preserving and embell-

ishing Bharat’s stature as a formidable societal and classical civilizational force to reckon with amongst comity of nations. From time to time, RSS-inspired organizations globally have been contributing their time and efforts in community service, natural disasters and supporting most vulnerable sections of the society in different countries,” they said.

Citing census data, the signatories said minorities have grown or remained stable in India, unlike in Pakistan and Bangladesh, where their populations have declined since Partition.

They noted that Hindus comprised about 20.5 per cent in undivided Pakistan in 1947 but now they account for around 1.5-2 per cent in Pakistan and 7-8 per cent in Bangladesh (then East Pakistan), down from about 20-22 per cent in 1951.

The CAPF (General Administration) Bill 2026: A landmark step towards a stronger, more humane and unified security framework for India



In the course of my service from leading anti-Naxal operations as Superintendent of Police in Odisha’s remote and insurgency-affected districts like Koraput, Nabarangpur and Nuapada, to commanding ITBP battalions at altitudes exceeding 15,000 feet along the Indo-Tibetan border, and finally guiding the Odisha Police as Director General, I have witnessed how India’s internal and border security depends on two equally vital pillars: operational synergy across institutions and genuine care for the men and women who serve on the front lines.

The Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill 2026 stands as a historic achievement that strengthens both pillars simultaneously. For the very first time since Independence, this single, comprehensive legislation codifies and unifies the administrative framework governing the five major Central Armed Police Forces—CRPF, BSF, CISF, ITBP and SSB—replacing a patchwork of separate rules, executive instructions and ad-hoc practices with clear, transparent statutory provisions.

This codification is transformative. It brings recruitment, promotions, cadre review, service conditions, disciplinary procedures, welfare measures, postings, transfers and grievance redressal under one legal umbrella. What were once discretionary administra-

tive decisions or subject to frequent changes now become enforceable statutory rights. For the over ten lakh personnel—especially the constabulary who form the true backbone of these forces—this shift delivers greater certainty, predictability, fairness and dignity throughout their careers.

The Bill is particularly landmark for the jawans and lower ranks who endure the harshest conditions: months-long deployments in dense forests, snow-bound Himalayan passes, scorching deserts, or high-risk industrial security duties. By converting welfare provisions, timely promotions, medical facilities, family accommodation norms, leave entitlements and pension-related matters into codified law, it ensures these hard-earned entitlements are no longer dependent



on changing administrative whims. This is not merely procedural reform; it is a humane recognition of the extraordinary sacrifices made by constables, head constables and assistant commandants who risk their lives daily for national security.

During my district tenure in Odisha in the 1990s and early 2000s, I saw how prolonged uncertainty over promotions, postings and welfare support affected morale among the ranks who bore the heaviest burden in counter-insurgency operations. Later, while leading ITBP compa-



nies and battalions in Ladakh and Arunachal, the same issues surfaced—troops operating in sub-zero temperatures with limited connectivity, yet facing delays in routine service matters. A clear, statutory framework would have provided the psychological and material reassurance that every soldier deserves. As DGP, when coordinating large-scale CAPF deployments during elections, communal situations or Maoist incidents, I observed how predictable service rules directly enhanced motivation, discipline and operational effectiveness among the constabulary.

Importantly, it must be recognized that IPS officers are recruited directly at the level of Superintendents of Police (SP), while Assistant Commandants in the CAPFs enter at a rank equivalent to Deputy Superintendents of Police (DySP) in state police ser-

vices. Although both recruitments occur through the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), the IPS is selected via the country’s most rigorous and competitive examination—the Civil Services Examination—where only around 150-200 of the nation’s top talents are chosen from millions of applicants each year. This rigorous selection process equips IPS officers with a broad, strategic perspective, administrative acumen, and the ability to navigate complex federal and inter-agency dynamics—qualities that have proven invaluable in coordinating operations across state and central forces.

Additionally, unlike military services, which often operate in more defined combat environments, CAPF services frequently require interaction with civilians in diverse and sensitive contexts—such as crowd control, election

duties, anti-insurgency operations in populated areas, or industrial security. This demands a humane, citizen-centric approach, emphasizing restraint, public trust-building, and adherence to rule of law even under extreme provocation. The statutory framework in the Bill reinforces this by codifying service conditions that support professional, empathetic policing rather than purely militaristic responses.

At the same time, the Bill creates hundreds of new senior posts for CAPF cadre officers through structured cadre reviews and restructuring, opening genuine, merit-based pathways for advancement. It honours longstanding aspirations while wisely preserving the time-tested practice of All India Service deputation at apex command levels. This balanced approach ensures that the senior leadership retains the

broad national perspective, cross-institutional networks and federal coordination ability that I relied upon throughout my career—whether liaising between state police and CRPF during joint anti-Naxal drives, or aligning ITBP operations with Army, IB and local administration along sensitive borders.

This integration is the living embodiment of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel’s visionary All India integrative approach. As the chief architect of modern India’s administrative framework, Sardar Patel insisted that the Indian Police Service must function as a national steel frame officers who move seamlessly across states, central forces and intelligence agencies, carrying with them a unified understanding of India’s security needs. He designed the IPS precisely so that leadership would never be confined to narrow institutional silos but would always remain connected to the larger republican order. The CAPF Bill 2026 upholds this foundational Patel doctrine by maintaining the integrative mechanism at the highest levels while simultaneously empowering CAPF officers with statutory rights and expanded opportunities.

The nation has repeatedly seen the strength of this integrative model through the supreme sacrifices of legendary IPS officers who operated across multiple systems with courage and distinction. Randhir Prasad Verma, IPS, walked alone into a bank seized by armed Khalistani terrorists in Dhanbad in 1991 and laid down his life fighting them with his service pistol earning the Ashoka Chakra posthumously. Hemant Karkare,

co-ordinated the 26/11 Mumbai response under live fire at Cama Hospital before making the ultimate sacrifice. KS Vyas, IPS, architect of the Greyhounds counter-insurgency doctrine in Andhra Pradesh, was assassinated by Naxals for his pioneering work that later shaped CRPF’s CoBRA units. These officers, and countless others like them, proved in blood that leadership forged through national integration delivers results that no single-force silo can match.

From a national standpoint, this first-ever comprehensive statutory codification ends decades of fragmentation, modernises governance, reinforces institutional integrity and upholds Sardar Patel’s vision of a cohesive, integrative security architecture for a diverse federation.

Reflecting on decades of service—from jungle patrols in Odisha to high-altitude border vigil and statewide command—I am convinced that the CAPF (General Administration) Bill 2026 will significantly enhance national security by combining greater fairness and motivation for the constabulary with the unified command ethos our country requires. It is reform that is fair, humane, forward-looking and firmly in the national interest.

This landmark legislation deserves the wholehearted support of every citizen who values a stronger, more equitable and truly unified security apparatus for our great democracy.

Former Inspector General, Indo-Tibetan Border Police, Ex Director General of Police, Odisha

States Focus



KERALA POLLS: BJP RELEASES THIRD LIST OF 11 CANDIDATES

The BJP on Saturday released its third list of 11 candidates for the Kerala Assembly Polls, fielding Karamana Jayan from Thiruvananthapuram. According to the list, Raveendranath Vakathanam will join the fray from Puthuppally, KR Rajesh from Chavara, RS Arun Raj from Chadayamangalam, and V Ratheesh from Peerumade seat. Vivek Gopan will contest from Aruvikkara seat, TN Suresh from Kovalam, and S Rajasekharan Nair from Neyyattinkara seat. The party has fielded Ajimon from Mavelikkara seat, BS Anoop from Chirayinkeezhu, and Pandalam Prathapan from Adoor seat.



JAMMU CELEBRATES EID WITH PRAYERS FOR GLOBAL PEACE

Amid tight security arrangements, Eid al-Fitr was celebrated with religious fervour and traditional gaiety across the Jammu region on Monday, with a large number of Muslims gathering at various eidgahs and mosques to offer prayers for peace and an end to the conflicts in the Middle East. Eid al-Fitr marks the end of the holy month of Ramzan, which is observed through fasting, prayers and charity, and ushers in a festival of joy, togetherness and thanksgiving. Hundreds of devotees offered prayers at different mosques and eidgahs across the region, with the main congregation held at the eidgah on Residency Road in Jammu, followed by gatherings at the Mecca Masjid in Bathindi and the Jamia Masjid in Talab Khatikan.

Rahul Gandhi says Govt lacks strategy on economy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday accused the Modi Government of lacking both direction and strategy necessary to manage the current economic situation facing the nation.

He also expressed concern that the Government will raise the prices of petrol, diesel and LPG following the elections in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Assam, Kerala and the UT of Puducherry

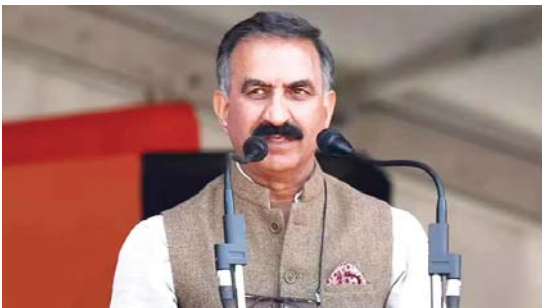


scheduled next month. The leader of opposition in Lok Sabha said the weakening value of rupee against the US dollar and a sharp rise in industrial fuel prices will inevitably lead to price hikes affecting every Indian.



States Focus

TMC plans twin-front campaign from March 24



CM Sukhu presents ₹54,928 crore budget for 2026-27

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Saturday presented ₹54,928-crore budget for the financial year 2026-27 in the State assembly. Sukhu, who was presenting his fourth budget, started his speech by saying that the discontinuation of the revenue deficit grant (RDG) has impacted the annual budget and accused the BJP for not supporting the State's interests. "The opposition BJP has not sided with the State in these hard times and history will never forget them," Sukhu said, drawing immediate reaction from the BJP members.



Congress, Rahul Gandhi are B-team of BJP: Kerala CM

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Saturday hit out against the Congress and its leader Rahul Gandhi, accusing them of being the B-team of the BJP. Vijayan made the accusation during an interview given to PTI videos. In response to a query regarding Rahul's recent remark that central agencies have arrested or called for questioning other opposition leaders in the country, except the Kerala CM, the Marxist veteran accused the Congress leader and his party of acting as the B-team of the BJP. He also accused the Congress of appeasement politics and seeking the support of groups engaged in majority and minority communalism.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

With barely a month left for the first phase of the West Bengal assembly elections, the ruling TMC is preparing to unleash a twin-front campaign blitz led by party supremo and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in north Bengal and her nephew Abhishek in the southern districts, a strategy aimed at countering the BJP across two distinct electoral battle-grounds.

Party sources said Mamata Banerjee will formally launch the campaign in north Bengal, a region long regarded as a BJP stronghold, with a mega rally at the Alipurduar Parade Ground on March 24. The chief minister is also scheduled to address meetings the same day at Matigara in Darjeeling district and Maynaguri in Jalpaiguri. The move signals a clear

attempt by the TMC leadership to wrest back political ground in the northern belt, where the BJP had made deep inroads in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls and retained a strong presence through the 2021 assembly elections.

Political observers note that despite the TMC's improved performance in the 2024 parliamentary polls, north Bengal continues to remain a key theatre of contest, with the BJP hoping to consolidate its foothold among Rajbanshi, tribal and migrant communities.

"Mamatadi herself leading the charge from Alipurduar sends a message that the party is taking the BJP's challenge in north Bengal seriously," a senior TMC leader said.

The chief minister is expected to leave for north Bengal after addressing a workers' conference in her own constituency, Bhabanipur, on Sunday evening, where she is



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee addressing a gathering on the occasion of Eid al-Fitr at Red Road in Kolkata, West Bengal on Saturday

likely to outline the party's booth-level strategy for the upcoming polls.

The meeting at Ahindra Mancha in Chetla will bring together booth workers and local leadership of the Bhabanipur assembly segment, including state TMC president Subrata Bakshi, Kolkata Mayor Firhad Hakim,

South Kolkata district president Debasish Kumar and councillors from the area.

The mobilisation assumes significance as Bhabanipur, traditionally considered Mamata Banerjee's political backyard, has emerged as a closely watched constituency after the BJP fielded Leader of Opposition Suvendu

World under threat of war, only dialogue can lead to solutions: VP

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagpur

The world is under the threat of war and only dialogue can lead to solutions, Vice President CP Radhakrishnan said on Saturday.

Addressing a gathering of the 29th national session of the Indian Youth Parliament at the RSS' Dr Hedgewar Smruti Mandir complex in Reshimbagh here, he also said speaking in one's mother tongue is not about being regional but about being original.

The theme of the 4-day Youth Parliament is 'Indian Languages & Developed India-2047'. "When the



VP CP Radhakrishnan addressing the gathering during the 29th National Session of Indian Youth Parliament in Nagpur on Saturday. Maharashtra Governor Jishnu Dev Varma and others also seen

whole world is under the threat of war, only dialogue can lead to solutions. The Youth Parliament teaches us the importance of respectful debate, listening to

diverse perspectives, and finding solutions through dialogue," he said.

"The theme on languages is the need of the hour. Bharat has so many lan-

guages. Everyone loves their own mother, every one loves their own mother tongue, mother religion, but it does not mean we should not respect the mother of another person. When we speak our mother tongues, we are not being regional. We are being original," he asserted.

Each language carries its own heritage, yet they together create a collective cultural harmony that defines India, the Vice President opined.

"There is no God bigger than Bharat Mata," he said.

Radhakrishnan said he recently released the updated translated version

of the Constitution in Tamil and Gujarati and praised Prime Minister Narendra Modi for taking the initiative to make it available in so many languages.

"For the first time, the Constitution has been made available in languages like Dogri, Santhali, and many others. The Union Government is making several efforts to protect and promote the linguistic diversity of Bharat," he said.

Commenting on the ongoing Budget Session of Parliament, Radhakrishnan, also the chairperson of the Rajya Sabha, said he was happy to see constructive debates in the House.

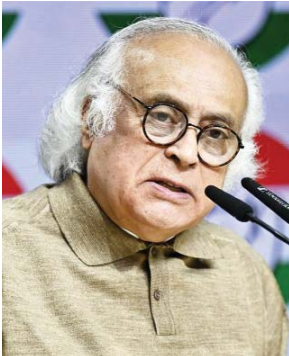
Modi govt's failure to condemn attacks on Iran shows betrayal of India's civilisational values, says Congress

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Saturday said the Modi Government's failure to condemn the US-Israel aerial assault on Iran and "force a brutal regime change" there reflected the "moral cowardice" and "political betrayal" of India's civilisational values.

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said Prime Minister Narendra Modi also did not use his much-claimed friendship with the US president (Donald Trump) and the Israeli prime minister (Benjamin Netanyahu) to bring about a cease-fire.

In a statement shared on X, Ramesh said it has been exactly 21 days or three weeks since the aerial assault of the



US and Israel on Iran began.

It has also been 23 days since the prime minister returned from his "much-trumpeted" visit to Israel, he said. "Has the Modi Government condemned or criticised or deplored the brutal efforts of the US and Israel to force a regime change and State collapse that could lead to civil war in Iran? The answer is NO," the Congress leader said.

"Has the Modi Government condemned or criticised or deplored the launch of the heavy aerial assault on Iran by the US and Israel that has now led to

severe economic dislocations everywhere, including India? The answer is NO.

"Has the Modi Government condemned or criticised or deplored the targeted assassinations of top Iranian leaders by the US and Israel that continue unabated? The answer is NO.

"Has the Modi Government condemned or criticised or deplored the efforts of the US and Israel to force a regime change and State collapse that could lead to civil war in Iran? The answer is NO," the Congress leader said.

"Has the Modi Government mounted serious diplomatic efforts and initiatives to bring the bombing of Iran and Iran's attacks on energy and other essential infrastructure in the Gulf countries to an

immediate halt? Has the PM used his much-claimed friendship with the US president and the Israeli PM to bring about a cease-fire? The answer is NO," he added.

"These 4 NOs reflect the moral cowardice and political betrayal of India's civilisational values," the Congress general secretary alleged.

The three-week war has shown no signs of abating, with Israel saying Iran continued to fire missiles at it early Saturday, while Saudi Arabia said it downed 20 drones in just a couple of hours in the country's eastern region, which is home to major oil installations.

Iran has also fired at energy sites in the Gulf countries and has now threatened recreational and tourist sites worldwide.

BJP slams Rahul Gandhi over Uttam Nagar remarks, accuses Congress of politics

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Saturday lashed out at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, accusing him of engaging in "appeasement politics" over the Uttam Nagar incident in which a Dalit youth was killed during Holi celebrations.

Addressing a press conference, BJP national spokesperson Guru Prakash Paswan accused Gandhi of political opportunism, claiming that whenever faced with a

choice between social justice and minority appeasement, he is always found siding with the latter. He also criticised Gandhi for not visiting Uttam Nagar after the Dalit man was murdered. "The Uttam Nagar incident proves one thing: whenever there is a choice between social justice, constitutional values, and minority appeasement, Rahul Gandhi and the Congress party have always chosen appeasement," Paswan said at the BJP headquarters here.

"The incident once again proves that when given a choice, Congress resorts to political opportunism and appeasement," he said.

The remarks came after Gandhi, in a post on X, accused the BJP of stoking hatred and violence over the Uttam Nagar case.

"The people of Uttam Nagar have paid a heavy price for violence -- on one hand, a young man, Tarun, has lost his life; on the other, an entire family is facing harassment. They do not



want any more bloodshed," Gandhi said.

"It is only the BJP and its ecosystem that seek violence -- exploiting every opportunity to stoke hatred and bake the bread of violence on the fire of division," he added.

Gandhi alleged that the BJP wants to keep the country entangled in Hindu-Muslim divisions so that people do not question the prime minister on issues such as national security, energy and food security and strategic sovereignty.

PM's competence, foresight protected India from global crisis: Rajnath

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Haldwani (Uttarakhand)

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday credited Prime Minister Narendra Modi's competence and foresight for "safeguarding" India from the ripple effects of global instability, asserting that the country has remained secure despite the escalating conflict in West Asia.

Speaking at an event here on the completion of four years of the Pushkar Singh Dhami-led Government's second term in Uttarakhand, the defence minister backed the prime minister's stance that "war is not a solution"



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh addressing the gathering during an event marking four years of the State Government in Haldwani

and called for a resolution through dialogue and diplomacy.

"The world is passing through a period of crisis. The continuous attacks in West Asia are a matter of concern for the global community. Our prime minister has clearly stated that a resolution will only emerge through dialogue and diplomacy," Singh said in a post on X in Hindi.

"When the world is at war, no country can remain unaffected. India may also be impacted during such times, but our prime minister, through his competence, capability and foresight, has ensured that the country

does not get trapped in these crisis," he said.

Singh noted that the ongoing attacks in West Asia are a matter of concern for the global community. "The efforts being made by Modi ji at a global level to resolve this crisis deserve full support," he added.

While addressing the event, Singh lauded the Uttarakhand Government for becoming the first in the country to implement the Uniform Civil Code (UCC).

He maintained that the UCC was a provision envisioned by the makers of the Constitution, but was long delayed due to the "politics of appeasement" by parties

like the Congress.

"While other parties play politics to form Governments, the BJP does so for nation-building," Singh remarked, praising Dhami for his "dhurandhar" (prodigious) performance over the last four years.

"After observing his work over the past four years, he should now be called 'Dhurandhar Dhami'. He has worked at a frantic pace. I could never have imagined that a Government in a small State like Uttarakhand could function with such speed. In several sectors, the State has secured the top position in the country," the defence minister said.

Judicial reforms commission needed to cut court backlog, says Justice Nagarathna

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Justice BV Nagarathna of the Supreme Court on Saturday called for the creation of a judicial reforms commission to reduce mounting pendency in the courts, saying systemic incentives across stakeholders were contributing to delays in justice delivery.

She was speaking at the Supreme Court Bar Association's (SCBA) first National Conference on the theme "Reimagining judicial governance: strengthening institutions for democratic justice" here.

Nagarathna, who was part of the panel session addressing "From Pendency to Prompt Justice: Rethinking Justice Delivery in Indian Courts," said, this reforms commission must have membership not only from the judiciary of the Supreme Court, the High Court, as well as the District judiciary, but also have members from the Bar, Attorney General, Solicitor General, and also certain members representing the Bar at the institutional level, such as the Bar President, and from the Government side to enable



an inter-institutional dialogue on reducing pendency.

She reflected that, from the point of view of various stakeholders, a litigant gains from the status quo, to proceed to prolong proceedings. "A lawyer or an advocate loves adjournments and postponement because he/she benefits from per appearance and extended timelines. A Government department reduces bureaucratic risk by appealing rather than accepting defeat.

"A judge, and particularly a trial judge, is always acting with caution because he/she is confronted with appellate reversal, and therefore he/she prefers procedural caution rather than having an aggressive docket control. Each of these decisions is individually rational, but how does it help the system? It is only leading to systemic delay," she added.

India's milk production up from 17 MT in 1950 to 247 MT in 2025: Official



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

Secretary, Department of Agricultural Research and Education (DARE) and Director General of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) M L Jat has said India's milk production rose from 17 million tonnes in 1950 to 247 MT in 2025.

Jat, a distinguished agronomist, highlighted dairy's dominance within the ₹7.25 lakh crore livestock sector -- contributing 65 per cent of output and driving 16 per cent of India's gross value added (GVA), which supports 46.1 per cent of the population.

"The Union Budget has allocated ₹6,153 crore for animal husbandry (up 16 per cent) to recruit 20,000 veterinarians, subsidize colleges/labs and provide cooperative tax relief, powering Viksit Bharat in 2047," he said, while addressing the 22nd convocation of ICAR-National Dairy Research Institute (ICAR-NDRI) at Karnal in Haryana on Friday.

According to an NDRI release, Jat said India's milk production surged from 17 MT (1950) to 247 MT (2025), led by Uttar Pradesh, with Punjab-Haryana topping yields and NITI Aayog projecting 480-606 MT demand by 2047.



PROSPECT

Govt modifies Mutual Credit Guarantee Scheme to support MSME manufacturers, exporters

The Finance Ministry on Saturday said the Mutual Credit Guarantee Scheme for MSMEs (MCGS-MSME) has been modified to support manufacturers and exporters, allowing a 5 per cent upfront contribution in tranches after the fourth year. As per the revised scheme, the services sector has been included in the scheme, and the cost of equipment/ machinery has been reduced up to 60 per cent of the project cost from the earlier 75 per cent, the finance ministry said in a statement. The National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company Ltd (NCGC) has operationalised the revised scheme since February 24, 2026. According to the modified scheme, the credit guarantee would expire after 10 years, as compared to the unspecified period in the earlier scheme. Elaborating on eligibility, it said, profitable units having exported at least 25 per cent of their sales turnover in each of the previous 3 financial years and satisfying certain export realisation conditions are eligible to avail the scheme. Guaranteed loan amount is pegged at ₹20 cr, and upfront contribution is 2 per cent of the loan amount, a maximum of ₹40 lakh, with 1 per cent each refundable in the 4th and 5th year of the guarantee period.

Make nutrition core Curriculum to curb India’s dual health burden

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Schools may hold the key to tackling India's growing nutrition crisis—from persistent malnutrition to rising lifestyle diseases—with experts now pushing to make nutrition education a core part of everyday learning.

At the third edition of the Nutrition Conclave, hosted by the Nourishing Schools Foundation in New Delhi, policymakers, educators, and industry leaders called for integrating nutrition literacy into school systems. They argued that early awareness can significantly influence lifelong health outcomes. The conversation comes at a time when India faces a dual burden: undernutrition in many regions and increasing cases of obesity, diabetes, and other metabolic disorders, often beginning at younger ages.

Speakers noted that while national programmes such as Poshan Abhiyaan, PM Poshan, and the School Health and Wellness

Programme under Ayushman Bharat have expanded access to food and health services, there is now a clear need to go beyond access and focus on behaviour change.

“India needs to re-establish its elemental connection with food,” said Arti Ahuja, former Secretary to the Government of India, stressing that nutrition policy must move towards a more holistic, multi-sectoral approach. “Efforts across the food system must converge into something concrete and actionable.” At the heart of the discussion was a simple idea: children who understand nutrition early are more likely to make healthier choices—not just for themselves, but within their families and communities.

Archana Sinha, Co-founder and CEO of the Nourishing Schools Foundation, highlighted this long-term impact. “The food choices children make tomorrow will be shaped by what they learn today. Schools are where this change can begin,” she said.

Let’s Celebrate Water Together Building a People’s Movement for Water



C R PATIL

On World Water Day, observed on 22 March, I extend my greetings to all citizens. This occasion is a reminder of the central role water plays in our lives and of our shared responsibility to conserve and protect it for the future.

Water sustains life, ecosystems, and economic activity. Yet, pressures on this vital resource are rising. India is home to nearly 18 percent of the world's population and livestock, but has access to only about 4 percent of global freshwater resources. Rapid urbanisation, rising demand, and climate change make efficient and responsible water management a national priority.

Recognizing this challenge, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has adopted an integrated approach to water governance. The creation of the Ministry of Jal Shakti brought diverse aspects of water management under a single framework, marking a decisive shift towards holistic planning.

This approach addresses water across its full cycle—focusing on conservation and groundwater recharge; strengthening storage with dams and reservoirs; enabling bal-

anced distribution via river interlinking; expanding access under programmes such as the Jal Jeevan Mission and modernised command area development; improving quality under initiatives like Namami Gange; and building resilience with research, innovation, and awareness. Together, these efforts reflect a comprehensive vision for long-term water security.

At the centre of this vision is the recognition that water management, in all its aspects, must become a people's movement. Government initiatives provide scale and direction, but lasting impact is achieved when citizens participate actively and take ownership. The Jal Jeevan Mission is being implemented as the world's largest programme to provide safe and adequate drinking water to every rural household.

Tap water connections have now reached over 15.8 crore rural households, improving quality of life. For millions of women, this has reduced the burden of fetching water, improved health outcomes, and enabled greater participation in education and livelihoods. Beyond infrastructure, it places strong emphasis on community participation, with Gram Panchayats and Village Water and Sanitation Committees at the centre, and women trained to monitor water quality, strengthening local ownership.

The Namami Gange programme has improved water quality and supported ecological restoration in the Ganga and its tributaries, leading to improvement in habitat

and numbers of key aquatic species, including the Gangetic dolphin. Alongside its focus on Nirmal and Aviral Ganga, it advances initiatives such as Arth Ganga and Jan Ganga, which place communities at the centre of river rejuvenation by linking livelihoods, awareness, and local participation with conservation efforts.

Water conservation has become a mass movement through the Jal Shakti Abhiyan. The Prime Minister's call of “Catch the Rain—where it falls, when it falls” has inspired action across the country. Under the “Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari” initiative, communities are undertaking rainwater harvesting, restoration of traditional water bodies, watershed development, and afforestation.

Since September 2024, these efforts have led to the creation of over 45 lakh water conservation structures, demonstrating how community participation can deliver results at scale when supported by Government initiatives. Across India, examples of such participation are visible. In Banaskantha, Gujarat, dairy cooperatives have partnered with farmers to build low-cost recharge structures. In Korea, Chhattisgarh, farmers have dedicated portions of their land for groundwater recharge. In urban areas, residential societies are adopting rainwater harvesting and reuse practices.

Initiatives like Karmabhumi se Matribhumi reflect a growing sense of responsibility, with individuals contributing to conservation efforts in their native places. Industry and agriculture play a critical role in ensuring water

security. Many industries are voluntarily adopting best practices such as water audits, recycling and reuse, Zero Liquid Discharge, and rainwater harvesting, supported by continued innovation in water technologies.

In agriculture, micro-irrigation, improved on-farm water management, and better utilisation of available resources are being adopted across regions, supported by programmes like the Modernisation of Command Area Development, helping enhance sustainability while supporting farmers' livelihoods. Urban India should also embrace a culture of conservation through rainwater harvesting, wastewater reuse, and sustainable planning. Every household, institution, and community has a role in ensuring responsible water use.

India's journey towards water security is a collective national endeavour, essential for building a Viksit Bharat. Water security ultimately depends not only on infrastructure and policy, but also on behavioural change.

On this World Water Day, let us move beyond awareness to action. If each citizen saves, reuses, or recharges even one litre of water, we conserve over 140 crore litres as a nation—an extraordinary impact from a simple act. Let conservation become a daily habit. A watersecure India will be built not by policy alone, but by the everyday choices of its people—where every drop is valued, every source is sustained, and every citizen becomes a custodian of this precious resource.

Author is Union Minister of Jal Shakti

Minister CR Patil warns urban water consumption is at unsustainable levels

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Urban households in India consume up to 2 lakh litres of water annually, raising concerns about long-term sustainability, Union Minister for Jal Shakti CR Patil said at a business forum in Surat this week.

Speaking at Corporate Connections India's “Big Hairy Audacious Forum (BHAFF)” held in Surat recently, Patil noted that urban residents use an average of 135 litres of water per day. “If current consumption patterns continue, will there be enough water for future generations?” he asked, highlighting the urgency of efficient water management.

Patil outlined the discrepancy between India's water availability and storage capacity. While the

country receives approximately 4,000 million cubic metres (MCM) of rainfall annually against a requirement of 1,120 MCM, its storage capacity is limited to around 750 MCM. This shortfall, he said, has increased reliance on groundwater, resulting in declining water tables.

The minister encouraged businesses and entrepreneurs to adopt rainwater harvesting measures to recharge groundwater and reduce pressure on existing water resources.

The two-day forum brought together entrepreneurs, founders, and business leaders from across India to discuss leadership, growth, and the future of business. Actor Arjun Kapoor, one of the event's speakers, emphasised the importance of connection and perspective.



He noted that the true strength of an artist lies in building emotional connections with audiences and stressed that effective money management is a skill that must be learned.

National Directors of Corporate Connections India, Gaurav VK Singhvi and Yash Vasant, said the forum aims to foster trust and collaboration among entrepreneurs beyond traditional networking.

The event featured sessions by industry leaders, including Hitesh Doshi, Amit Jain, Ravi Kant, and Vaishali Wagle, focusing on scaling businesses and leadership strategies. A highlight was a panel discussion on “Scaling from ₹100 crore to ₹1000 crore.” The forum concluded with an awards ceremony recognising contributions from members of the Corporate Connections India community.

Haryana CM resolves long pending access road issue In Gurugram’s Sector 85

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Gurugram

Residents of Sector 85, Gurugram, have received long-pending relief with the opening of the 24-metre sector road that connects the neighbourhood to the multi-utility corridor and Dwarka Expressway. The absence of a connecting road, forced thousands of families to rely on narrow, congested internal routes for daily travel.

The issue had remained unresolved for years until it was taken up in the District Public Grievance & Redressal Committee meeting chaired by the Chief Minister of Haryana Nayab Singh Saini. A breakthrough came when Godrej Properties purchased the private land parcel that had blocked the continuity of the road, with an intent to clear the obstruction and



have the 24 metre road link opened for public use.

During his speech, Minister for Industries & Commerce, Environment, Foreign Cooperation & Sainik Welfare, Rao Narbir Singh expressed, “I would like to express my gratitude to all the Haryana Government officials and to Godrej Properties, who demonstrated promptness in resolving this issue

and thanks to their tireless efforts that this long pending access issue has finally been opened.”

Ajay Kumar, Deputy Commissioner, Gurugram, said: “This issue was brought forward through the grievance committee. Under the guidance of the Chief Minister and with the collective efforts of the team, a solution was found. I would like to thank

Godrej Properties, the local farmers, and everyone who contributed to resolving this issue.”

With the road now functional, more than 7000 residents will benefit from direct access to the sector as originally planned.

Wing Commander (Retd) R.D. Deshpande, Secretary, RAWS(Rise Always Welfare Society) said, “The 24 metre road opening has brought a sense of relief to residents and passer-by. It is good to witness that authorities are listening to what the community is saying and doing something about it.

We are very thankful Minister in charge, district authorities and Godrej Properties who helped fix this problem that has been going on for a long time. The difference will be tangible in the lives of more than 7000 people.”

New community gym opens in Arunachal under Operation Sadbhavana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Itanagar

In a significant step towards strengthening nation-building efforts in remote border regions, the Indian Army has established a Community Fitness Centre & Gym at Gelemo village in Upper Subansiri District, Arunachal Pradesh, under Operation Sadbhavana (2025–26) as part of the Government of India's Vibrant Village Programme.

The project has been undertaken under the aegis of the Subansiri Yodha Brigade, a formation of the Spear Corps, as part of the Indian Army's continued outreach initiatives aimed at promoting development, empowering local youth and strengthening civil-military cooperation in border areas.

The newly established facility will provide vil-



lagers—particularly the youth—with access to modern fitness equipment and a dedicated space for physical training, recreation and community engagement.

The Community Fitness Centre is expected to play a vital role in fostering a culture of fitness, discipline and healthy living among the youth of Gelemo and nearby villages. By creating a positive and constructive environment for recreation and self-improvement, the

initiative seeks to channel the energy of young people towards productive pursuits while nurturing qualities of confidence, resilience and self-reliance.

The inauguration witnessed enthusiastic participation from the local community, including village elders, women and children, reflecting the strong bond between the Indian Army and the people of the region.

Residents of Gelemo expressed heartfelt appreciation for the Army's contin-

ued commitment to bringing meaningful development initiatives to remote border villages. The facility is expected to benefit a large number of youth and villagers across the surrounding areas.

Through Operation Sadbhavana, the Indian Army continues to play a pivotal role in enhancing the quality of life in remote regions by supporting initiatives in infrastructure development, sports promotion, education, healthcare and community welfare. These projects not only address local needs but also strengthen trust and partnership between the armed forces and border communities. The establishment of the Community Fitness Centre & Gym at Gelemo stands as another testament to the Indian Army's “Nation First” ethos.

NTPC, Africa50 to jointly develop power projects in Africa

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Building upon the discussions held during the meeting chaired by the Minister of Power, Manohar Lal Khattar, towards strengthening India – Africa cooperation in the power sector, the Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of NTPC, Gurdeep Singh, met Alain Ebobisse, Chief Executive Officer of Africa50, to explore avenues for deepening collaboration in Africa's energy landscape.

According to a Press release, the discussions focused on opportunities for joint development of power projects across the African continent, encompassing coal, gas, solar, wind, and floating solar initiatives. Both sides also deliberated on



potential cooperation in facilitating power trading across Africa. In addition, the possibility of entering into a comprehensive framework agreement covering a wide spectrum of collaboration in the power and energy sector of Africa was discussed.

The meeting was held on the sidelines of the Bharat Electricity Summit (BES) 2026, being conducted from March

19 to 22, 2026, at Yashobhoomi, New Delhi, under the aegis of the Ministry of Power, Government of India.

The engagement reflects NTPC's continued commitment to strengthening international partnerships and contributing to sustainable and diversified energy development across emerging markets.

HDFC Bank fires officials for gaps in client onboarding

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Days after the resignation of HDFC Bank chairman Atanu Chakraborty citing ethical concerns, the bank has terminated the services of three employees for gaps in client onboarding at its Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC) branch.

According to sources, HDFC Bank has fired three senior executives over the alleged mis-selling of Credit Suisse's additional tier-1 (AT-1) bonds.

Following the allegations of mis-selling, the local regulator — Dubai Financial Services Authority — barred HDFC Bank from onboarding new customers at its DIFC branch last September.

When approached for a comment, the bank said in a statement that it has identi-



fied certain gaps in client-onboarding requirements at its DIFC branch in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and completed a detailed and objective review of the matter.

“Appropriate remedial actions have been taken in line with internal policies. Personnel changes have been undertaken along with appropriate action as per the bank's conduct

regulation,” it said.

The HDFC Bank has well-established governance frameworks and continues to remain committed to maintaining high standards of compliance and regulatory adherence, it added.

Chakraborty abruptly resigned as the chairman of the country's second-biggest lender, citing ethical concerns, effective March 18.

This is the first time that a

part-time chairman of HDFC Bank left mid-way, raising concerns over the bank's functioning.

“Certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over last two years, are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics. This is the basis of my aforementioned decision,” Chakraborty said in his resignation letter dated March 17.

In the letter addressed to the chairman of the Governance, Nomination, Remuneration Committee, H K Bhanwala, Chakraborty said “there are no other material reasons for my resignation other than those stated above.”

Chakraborty was appointed as the part-time chairman of the bank effective May 5, 2021, almost a year after he retired as the economic

affairs secretary.

His term was extended for another three years in 2024, till May 4, 2027.

Chakraborty, a 1985-batch IAS officer of the Gujarat cadre, retired as the secretary of the Department of Economic Affairs in April 2020. Prior to that, he was the secretary of the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM). Both departments are under the finance ministry.

Chakraborty became the chairman during the reverse merger process of the bank with the parent entity — HDFC Limited — a leading mortgage firm in the country.

The merger of HDFC Limited with HDFC Bank became effective on July 1, 2023, creating a financial behemoth with a combined balance sheet of more than ₹18 lakh crore.

FROM THE WORLD

IRAN

UAE, others condemn attacks

Twenty-two countries on Saturday urged Iran to cease attacks and reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Countries including the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, the UK, Germany, France, Japan, South Korea and Australia have condemned Iran's attacks on commercial vessels as well as oil and gas facilities in the region.

"The effects of Iran's actions will be felt by people in all parts of the world, especially the most vulnerable," they said in a joint statement Saturday.

ISRAEL

Katz warns of escalations

Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz said that attacks against Iran will "increase significantly" in the coming week. Katz spoke on Saturday, hours after US President Donald Trump said he was considering "winding down" military operations in the West Asia.

"This week, the intensity of the attacks that the IDF and the US military will carry out against the Iranian terrorist regime and against the infrastructures on which it relies will increase significantly," Israel Katz said in a video statement.

RUSSIA

Attack on Iran condemned

Russian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Maria Zakharova called strikes on the Natanz nuclear enrichment facility "a brazen violation of international law". In a statement posted on the ministry's website Saturday, Zakharova said such "irresponsible actions" posed a "real risk of catastrophic disaster throughout the Middle East" and were "clearly aimed at further undermining peace, stability, and security in the region".

US pauses sanctions on Iranian oil stranded on tankers at sea

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Florida

US officials have announced that the Trump administration will lift sanctions on Iranian oil stranded at sea under a one-month license as the White House tries to bring down soaring oil prices. The pause applies to Iranian oil loaded on ships as of Friday and is set to end April 19.

Iran had earlier on Friday threatened to expand its retaliatory attacks to include recreational and tourist sites worldwide, as the US announced it was sending more warships and Marines to the region.

Hours later, President Donald Trump said on social media that his administration in fact was considering "winding down" military operations in the region. His post came after another climb in oil prices plunged the US stock market.

The mixed messages came as the war has shown no signs of abating.

Iran launched more attacks on Israel and energy sites in neighbouring Gulf Arab States, and the region marked one



of the holiest days on the Muslim calendar. Iranians were also celebrating the Persian New Year, known as Nowruz, a normally festive holiday, as Israeli airstrikes landed in Tehran.

With little information coming out of Iran, it was not clear how much damage its arms, nuclear or energy facilities have sustained in the punishing US and Israeli strikes, which began February 28, or even who was truly in charge of the

country. But Iran's attacks are still choking off oil supplies and raising food and fuel prices far beyond the Middle East.

The US and Israel have offered shifting rationales for the war, from hoping to foment an uprising that topples Iran's leadership to eliminating its nuclear and missile programmes. There have been no public signs of any such uprising, and no end to the war in sight.

Six injured in clash between two groups in southern Nepal

SHIRISH B PRADHAN

■ Kathmandu

Six people were injured as a clash between two communities turned violent, prompting the local administration to impose restrictive orders for an indefinite period in Kapilvastu district in southern Nepal on Saturday.

District Administration Office, Kapilvastu, enforced restrictive orders in parts of the Maharaigunj municipality on Saturday for an indefinite period.

A group of Hindus observing the Navaratri festival were reciting bhajans in the Bargadwa area of Maharjung municipality when a group of

Muslims celebrating Eid opposed it, saying the music was too loud for them, police said.

The friction resulted in the clash between the two groups, and as the clash turned violent, injuring half a dozen people, the police said they used baton charge and threw tear gas cells to disperse the crowd.

The local administration soon imposed restrictive orders to prevent the situation from further worsening.

As per the restrictive orders, any type of mass gathering, demonstration and rally was prohibited from 2 pm onward till the next notice.

(PTI)



Curfew imposed in southern Nepal after violent clashes between 2 groups PTI

Congress looks for exit plan as West Asia crisis drags on

LISA MASCAROAP

■ Washington

President Donald Trump took the United States to war without a vote of support from Congress, but lawmakers are increasingly questioning when, how and at what cost the war with Iran will come to an end.

Three weeks into the conflict, the toll is becoming apparent. At least 13 US military personnel have died, and more than 230 have been wounded.

A USD 200 billion request from the Pentagon for war funds is pending at the White House. Allies are under attack, oil prices are spiking, and thousands of US troops are deploying to the Middle East with no endgame in sight.

"The real question is: What ultimately are we trying to accomplish?" Sen Thom Tillis, R-NC, told The Associated Press.

"I generally support anything that takes out the mullahs," he said. "But at the end of the day, there has to be a kind of strategic articulation of the strategy, what our objectives are."

Trump said late Friday that he was considering "winding down" the military operations even as he outlined new objectives and goals.

The Republican president's decision to launch the US-Israel-led war with Iran is testing the resolve of Congress, which is controlled by his party. Republicans have largely stood by the commander in chief, but will soon be faced with more consequential wartime choices.

Under the War Powers Act, the president can conduct military operations for 60 days without approval from Congress. So far, Republicans have easily voted down several res-



olutions from Democrats designed to halt the military campaign.

But the administration will need to show a more comprehensive strategy ahead or risk blowback from Congress, lawmakers said, especially as they are simultaneously being asked to approve billions in new spending.

Trump's quip that the war will end "when I feel it in my bones" has drawn alarm.

"When he feels it in his bones? That's crazy," said Virginia Sen. Mark Warner, the top Democrat on the Senate Intelligence Committee.

The president's party appears unlikely to directly challenge him, even as the conflict drags on. House Speaker Mike Johnson has said the military operation will be over quickly.

"I do think the original mission is virtually accomplished now," Johnson, R-La., told the AP and others at the Capitol this week.

"We were trying to take out the ballistic missiles, and their means of production, and neuter the navy, and

UK condemns Iranian missile attack on Indian Ocean base

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Dubai

Britain has condemned "Iran's reckless attacks" after its military fired missiles at the UK-US air base on the island of Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean.

UK officials have not given details of the attempted strike, which was unsuccessful. It's unclear how close the missiles came to the base, which is about 2,500 miles (4,000 kilometres) from Iran.

The Ministry of Defence said Saturday that Iran's "lashing out across the region and holding hostage the Strait of Hormuz, are a threat to British interests and British allies."

Britain has not participated in US-Israeli attacks on Iran, but has allowed American bombers to use UK bases to attack Iran's missile sites. On Friday, the British Government said US bombers can also use UK bases, including Diego Garcia, in operations to prevent Iran attacking ships in the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran targeted the base before that UK statement. Attack on Diego Garcia raises questions about range of Iran's missiles

Iran currently has a self-imposed limit on its ballistic missile program, limiting their



range to 2,000 kilometres (1,240 miles). That puts all of the Mideast and some of Eastern Europe in range, but Diego Garcia would be far beyond it.

However, US officials long have alleged Iran's space program could allow it to build intercontinental ballistic missiles.

What is the Diego Garcia air base? The Diego Garcia air base is home to about 2,500 mostly American personnel and has supported US military operations from Vietnam to Iraq, Afghanistan and strikes on Yemen's Houthi rebels. Diego Garcia is part of the Chagos Islands, a remote archipelago in the middle of the Indian Ocean off the tip of India. The islands have been under British control since 1814.

is unlikely to win support. Senate Democratic leader Chuck Schumer of New York called the amount "preposterous".

The Defence Department's approved appropriations from Congress this year are more than \$800 billion, and Trump's tax breaks bill gave the Pentagon an additional \$150 billion over the next several years for various upgrades and projects.

Sen. Mazie Hirono, D-Hawaii, said the country has other priorities.

"How about not taking away funding for Medicaid, which will impact millions of people. How about making sure SNAP is funded," she said, referring to the health care and food assistance programs that were cut as part of last year's Republican tax reductions.

"These are things that we should be doing for the American people," she said.

Many lawmakers have recalled the decision by President George W. Bush in the aftermath of the September 11, 2001, attacks to come to Congress to seek an authorisation for the use of military force — a vote to support his proposed military actions in Afghanistan and later, Iraq. Tillis said Trump has latitude under the War Powers Act to conduct the military campaign, but that will soon shift.

"When you get into the 45-day mark, you've got to start articulating one of two things — an authorisation for the use of military force to sustain it beyond that or a very clear path on exit," he said.

"Those are really the options the administration needs to be thinking about."

(AP)

Iran: Execution fears grow after three hung to death this week

LEE KEATH/
JULIA FRANKEL/
SARAH EL DEEB

■ Beirut

A 19-year-old star wrestler and two other young men were hanged in Iran this week, raising alarm among rights groups that a wave of executions may be underway as authorities facing relentless attacks from the US and Israel seek to squelch public dissent.

The three men are the first to be executed from among the tens of thousands who were arrested during a January crackdown on nationwide protests. Rights groups say more than

100 others could face death sentences. The wrestler, Saleh Mohammadi, was hanged early Thursday morning — along with Mehdi Qasemi and Saeed Davoudi — in Qom, just south of the Capital, Tehran, according to State media.

They had been sentenced on charges of "moharabeh," or "waging war against God," for allegedly killing two police officers during protests in the city.

Amnesty International said the convictions of the three, and of others arrested during the protests, came in "grossly unfair trials" that used confessions extracted by torture. The executions



were "intended to instil fear in society and deter new protests" amid the US-Israeli war on Iran, said Mahmood Amiry-Moghaddam, director of Iran Human Rights, an Oslo-based group that has documented detentions.

Amiry-Moghaddam said he worries many more "executions of protesters and political prisoners may be imminent."

At least 27 arrested during protests face death sentences Amiry-Moghaddam

said his group has documented at least 27 death sentences that have been issued against people arrested during the protests. Another 100 face charges that carry the death penalty, and Iranian state media have aired hundreds of forced confessions to crimes punishable by death, he said.

Nationwide protests that began in late December peaked in the first week of January, prompting the deadliest crackdown by Iranian security forces since the Islamic Republic took power in 1979. A complete death toll has been hard to gauge because of internet restrictions by authorities.

(AP)

Pakistan won't allow terrorists from Afghanistan to spoil peace: Munir

SAJJAD HUSSAIN

■ Islamabad

Pakistan will not allow terrorists operating from Afghanistan to spoil peace and endanger its security, Chief of Army Staff and Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir said on Saturday.

Munir visited Kurram on the border with Afghanistan to spend Eid-ul-Fitr with the troops and officers, where he offered Eid prayers, according to a statement by the army.

During his interaction with troops and officers, he lauded their achievements during Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq, aimed at dismantling terrorist networks and ensuring lasting peace in the border regions. "He emphasised that terrorists operating from sanctuaries



across the border in Afghanistan will not be allowed to undermine Pakistan's security," the army said. Reaffirming Pakistan's commitment to regional peace and stability, Munir reiterated that Afghan soil must not be used by hostile elements for activities against Pakistan.

(PTI)

Surprise, embarrassment, unease in Japan after Trump uses Pearl Harbor to defend Iran war

FOSTER KLUG/
MARI YAMAGUCHI

■ Tokyo

Senior US and Japanese officials tend to shy away from anything but very careful public comments about Japan's 1941 sneak attack on US forces at Pearl Harbor.

So there was embarrassment, confusion and unease on Saturday in Japan after President Donald Trump casually used the World War II attack to justify his secrecy before launching the war against Iran.

The Japanese discomfort was compounded by the fact that country's Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi was sitting awkwardly at Trump's side as he spoke. Partly, the reaction is linked to the crucial secu-

rity and economic role that the US plays for Japan, its top ally in the region. Put simply, Japan needs to make sure the US relationship thrives. That's why Takaichi was in Washington.

But it's also a reflection of just how fresh the political debate about Japan's role in World War II remains here, even 80 years after its end.

Senior leaders, including Takaichi, have argued that Japan has apologised enough for what happened in the war. Takaichi herself has recently hinted at visiting Tokyo's controversial Yasukuni Shrine, where Japanese war criminals are honoured among the 2.5 million war dead.

It is, however, somewhat startling for Japan to see



these history questions spill over into a White House summit. On Friday, when

asked by a Japanese reporter why he didn't tell allies in Europe and Asia ahead of the

US attack on Iran, Trump cited Pearl Harbor to defend his decision, saying, "Who

knows better about surprise than Japan? Why didn't you tell me about Pearl Harbor, OK?" The liberal leaning Asahi newspaper said in an editorial Saturday that Trump's comments "should not be overlooked". "Making such a remark to justify a sneak attack and boast about its outcome is a piece of nonsense that ignores lessons from history," Asahi said.

Social media reaction has ranged from accusations of ignorance and rudeness by the US president to claims that he didn't see Japan as an equal partner. There were calls for Japan to protest what Trump said.

Tsuneo Watanabe, a senior fellow at the Sasakawa Peace Foundation, said in an online opinion piece published in

the Nikkei newspaper Saturday that the comment signalled that Trump was "not bound by existing American common sense".

"I get the impression that the comment was intended to bring the Japanese reporter (who asked the question) or Ms Takaichi into complicity in order to justify his sneak attack on Iran during diplomatic negotiations and without telling allied countries," Watanabe said.

There's also a feeling that an unspoken understanding exists between US and Japanese leaders to tread carefully on the subject. Both sides need each other, with Washington relying on Japan to host 50,000 troops and an array of powerful hi-tech weapons, and Japan relying

on the US nuclear umbrella to deter hostile, nuclear-armed neighbours. Japan's post-World War II constitution bans the use of force except for its self-defence, but Takaichi and other officials are now seeking to expand the military's role.

When it comes to US-Japan reconciliation, many here look to the example of former leaders Barack Obama and Shinzo Abe, who in 2016 paid tribute together at the Arizona Memorial at Pearl Harbor and at the Hiroshima Peace Park.

Takaichi, a hard-line conservative, was praised for not reacting to the comments by Trump, letting them pass with a roll of her eyes and a glance at her ministers seated nearby.

(AP)

Jury finds Elon Musk liable for misleading investors

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ San Francisco

A jury has found Elon Musk liable for defrauding investors by deliberately driving down Twitter's stock price in the tumultuous months leading up to his 2022 acquisition of the social media company for \$44 billion. But it absolved him of some fraud allegations, finding that he did not "scheme" to mislead investors.

The civil trial in San Francisco centred on a class-action lawsuit filed just before Musk took control of Twitter, which he later renamed X. Jurors were asked to decide if two tweets and comments Musk made

on a podcast in May 2022 amounted to him intentionally defrauding Twitter shareholders, who sold their shares based on Musk's statements.

The nine-person jury returned the verdict after nearly four days of deliberation, nearly three weeks after the trial began on March 2. They said that while Musk was liable for misleading investors with two tweets - including one that said the Twitter deal was "temporarily on hold," he did not do so with a statement he made on a podcast and that he did not intentionally "scheme" to defraud investors.

The jury awarded shareholders between about \$3 and \$8 per stock per day as



damages, which the plaintiffs' lawyers said amounts to about \$2.1 billion in stock and another \$500 million in options. Musk's fortune is currently estimated at about \$814 billion, much of it tied up in Tesla shares. "It's an important victory, not just for investors of Twitter, but for the public markets," said Mark Molumphy, an attorney for the plaintiffs. "I think the jury's verdict sends a strong

message that just because you're a rich and powerful person, you still have to obey the law, and no man is above the law." Musk's legal team referenced other cases Musk won and said they will appeal. "Last month, Elon won the largest appellate victory in this country's history after getting an unfair shake at the trial level. Earlier today, in a Texas court, he won another appellate victory in which the trial judge was reversed," the legal team at Quinn Emanuel Urquhart & Sullivan said in a statement. "We view today's verdict, where the jury found both for and against the plaintiffs and found no fraud scheme, as a bump in the road. And we look forward to

vindication on appeal."

Much of the trial focused on Musk's claims about the number of bots on Twitter. Musk testified that Twitter had a much higher number of fake and spam accounts than the 5 per cent it disclosed in regulatory filings. He used what he called Twitter's misrepresentation of the number of fake accounts on its service as a reason to retreat from the purchase.

After Musk tried to back out, Twitter went to court in Delaware to force him to honor his original deal. Just before that case was scheduled to go to trial, Musk reversed course again and agreed to pay what he had originally promised.

Gautam Singhania injured in speedboat accident in Maldives



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Male

Raymond Group Chairman & Managing Director Gautam Hari Singhania has sustained injuries, while two Indian nationals are reported missing after a speedboat capsized near Felidhoo island in the Maldives, according to local media reports.

There were seven people on board at the time of the incident near Vaavu atoll early Friday morning. Two women - a British national and a Russian national - and five Indian men were on board, the Edition.mv reported.

Police said five people fell into the sea when the vessel overturned, including the Russian woman and four Indian men.

Singhania, 60, who was among the tourists, has been rescued.

Citing police, news portal

Adhadhu reported that he sustained minor injuries in the accident.

He was discharged from the hospital after treatment, it added.

"The two missing persons are Indian nationals," police said, adding that search operations are on.

"The speedboat belongs to his yacht, TT Ashena. The Maldivian Coast Guard is still looking for two people who went missing in the accident," Adhadhu reported.

Citing sources, it said that the vessel involved in the accident was a Cigarette racing boat designed to be driven at high speeds.

Maldives National Defence Force's Male Area Command Coast Guard Second Squadron is searching for the missing individuals. The incident occurred about two nautical miles southwest of Keyodhoo, MNDF said.

Indian-origin US judge guilty of money laundering

SEEMA HAKHU KACHRU
■ Houston (US)

An Indian-origin county judge has been convicted of money laundering following a jury verdict in a high-profile campaign finance case in the US State of Texas and faces removal from office after official sentencing on June 16.

KP George's conviction, a third-degree felony under Texas law, carries a possible sentence of two to 10 years in prison and a fine of up to \$10,000. George, who serves as county judge of Fort Bend County - one of the most

the funds were reimbursements for personal loans he had extended to his campaign.

The jury returned its verdict after several hours of deliberations, following which George was taken into custody in the courtroom. He was later released on bond and walked out of the Fort Bend County Jail around 8 pm on Friday following the guilty verdict.

George has opted for the judge to decide his sentence.

The sentencing hearing has been scheduled for June 16.



diverse counties in the country with a significant Indian-American population - was found guilty of misusing campaign funds for personal expenses.

According to prosecutors, George transferred over \$46,000 from his campaign account into personal accounts and used the money for private purposes, including a home-related payment.

The defence argued that

District attorneys in the courtroom told FOX 26 news portal that, according to the law, George is to be removed from office upon conviction; however, his official removal will not happen until after he's officially sentenced. (PTT)

Fort Bend County commissioners can then split George's responsibilities, or have someone fill in as interim, it added.

Russian strike on Zaporizhzhia kills 2 as Ukraine seeks to move forward peace talks

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kyiv

A Russian drone attack on the city of Zaporizhzhia killed at least two people on Saturday, a Ukrainian official said, ahead of expected US-Ukraine talks.

Zaporizhzhia regional head Ivan Fedorov said a man and a woman were killed and two children wounded when a Russian drone hit a private house in the morning.

The attack came ahead of the expected US-Ukraine talks, which Ukrainian state media reported would take place later in the day in Miami.



Representative image

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said late Thursday he had sent an official delegation to the United States in a bid to move forward suspended US-brokered talks on ending Russia's invasion.

Trilateral talks involving Russia, which have yet to produce any breakthrough on key issues, have been on ice while the Iran war has dominated international attention.

The White House did not

confirm any meeting with the Ukrainian delegation.

Zelenskyy said the main tasks in the US will be to ensure that the trilateral talks resume and that Washington continues to allow other NATO countries to purchase American weapons to send to Ukraine.

A senior Kremlin official indicated Friday that a new round of US-mediated negotiations between Moscow and Kyiv will likely take place soon.

"The pause is temporary; we hope it's temporary regarding the continuation of the trilateral format," said Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov.

At least 10 people killed in South Korean factory fire

KIM TONG-HYUNG
■ Seoul

South Korean rescue workers on Saturday recovered 10 bodies from the charred wreckage of an auto parts factory in the central city of Daejeon, where a blaze likely triggered by an explosion injured at least 59 others and left four missing.

The Ministry of the Interior and Safety said 25 people were seriously injured but officials didn't immediately confirm whether any were in life-threatening condition. More than 500 firefighters, police and emergency personnel were deployed to contain the fire and conduct rescue operations after the fire broke out Friday afternoon.

Videos and photos from the scene



showed thick grey smoke billowing from the complex and some workers jumping from a building.

Nam Deuk-woo, fire chief of the city's Daedeok district, said the blaze destroyed a factory building that firefighters initially could not enter over

fears it might collapse. Searches for the missing workers began late Friday after officials deployed unmanned firefighting robots to cool the structure and conducted a safety inspection.

The fire was reported at about 1.18 pm Nam said the cause was not immediately known, but the blaze appeared to have spread rapidly, with witnesses reporting an explosion. Firefighters focused on preventing the blaze from spreading to an adjacent facility and removing chemicals from the site.

Nam said workers recovered more than 100 kg of highly reactive chemicals from the site.

Some people were injured when they jumped from the building to escape, while others suffered from smoke inhalation, Nam said. (AP)

Russia thwarts protests over blocking of popular messaging app, but frustration persists

DASHA LITVINOVA
■ Moscow

In one Russian city, officials blocked a rally due to a "tree inspection." Elsewhere, they blamed snow removal problems or still-existing COVID-19 restrictions. And in one location, administrators argued that the reason for the protest didn't exist.

Authorities in nearly a dozen Russian regions in recent weeks cited various excuses to prevent demonstrations against internet censorship and the blocking of the popular messaging



app Telegram. In most cases, they succeeded.

Mindful of a crackdown on dissent since the 4-year-old invasion of Ukraine, activists decided not to risk holding

unauthorised rallies, even if they weren't about the war. Some went to court to challenge Government refusals to authorise pickets, while others scaled them

back to smaller indoor gatherings. But the disapproval persists across the political spectrum over moves against Russia's second-most popular messaging app, adding to frustrations over a growing list of various issues that plague the country.

"Clearly the situation has changed, the laws have become stricter, but the protest hasn't gone anywhere," said Alexander Sustov, a legislator in Russia's far eastern Primorye region, where a pro-Telegram rally was blocked last month. (AP)

Colombian president 'priority target' in drug probe

JIM MUSTIAN/JOSHUA GOODMAN/
ALANNA DURKIN RICHER
■ New York

Colombian President Gustavo Petro has been designated a "priority target" by the US Drug Enforcement Administration as federal prosecutors in New York probe his alleged ties to drug traffickers, according to people familiar with the matter and records seen by The Associated Press.

DEA records show Petro has surfaced in multiple investigations dating to 2022, many based on interviews with confidential informants. The alleged crimes the DEA has investigated include his possible dealings with Mexico's Sinaloa cartel and a scheme to leverage his "total peace" plan to benefit prominent traffickers who contributed to his presidential campaign. The records also suggest the use of law



Colombian President Gustavo Petro

enforcement to smuggle cocaine and fentanyl through Colombian ports.

The "priority target" label is reserved for suspects DEA deems to have a "significant impact" on the drug trade.

Petro denied all ties to drug traffickers and maintained he never accepted their funds during his campaign.

Writing on X Friday, he argued that US legal proceedings would ultimate-

ly dismantle accusations from the Colombian far right, a group he claims is actually the one involved with traffickers.

Colombia's Embassy in Washington downplayed what it called "unverified" and anonymous reports of preliminary law enforcement investigations against Petro.

"The reported insinuations have no legal or factual basis," the embassy said in a statement.

In recent months, prosecutors in Brooklyn and Manhattan have been questioning drug traffickers about their ties to Petro and specifically about allegations the Colombian president's representatives solicited bribes to block their extradition to the United States, according to one of the people who wasn't authorised to discuss the ongoing inquiry and spoke to The Associated Press on condition of anonymity. (AP)

Hawaii suffers its worst flooding in 20 years; forecasters warn of more rain

JENNIFER SINCO KELLEHER/
AUDREY MCAVOY
■ Honolulu

Hawaii suffered its worst flooding in more than 20 years as heavy rains fell on soil already saturated by downpours from a winter storm a week ago, officials said Friday while warning that still more rain was expected during the weekend.

Muddy floodwaters smothered vast stretches of Oahu's North Shore, a community world-renowned for its big-wave surfing. Raging waters lifted homes and cars and prompted evacuation orders for 5,500 people north of Honolulu. Authorities cautioned that a 120-year-old dam could fail.

Gov. Josh Green said the



cost of the storm could top \$1 billion, including damage to airports, schools, roads, people's homes and a Maui hospital in Kula. "This is going to have a very serious consequence for us as a State," Greensaid at a news conference.

Most of the State was under

a flood watch, with Haleiwa and Waialua in northern Oahu under a flash flood warning, according to the National Weather Service.

Green said his chief of staff spoke to the White House and received assurances the islands would have federal support.

Himalayan glaciers' ice loss rates doubled since 2000: ICIMOD report

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Glaciers across the Hindu Kush Himalaya are melting at an accelerating rate, with ice loss rates doubling since 2000, even as they lost 12 per cent of their area between 1990 and 2020, two reports by ICIMOD said Saturday.

Coinciding with the World Day for Glaciers, observed annually on March 21, the reports were published by the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD), a regional interGovernmental body headquartered in Kathmandu, providing the most comprehensive evidence of glacier change in the region.

The reports 'Changing Dynamics of Glaciers in the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH



Region from 1990 to 2020' and 'HKH Glacier Outlook 2026: Insights from 50 years of Himalayan Glacier Monitoring' reveal a total loss of up to 27 metres of ice thickness since 1975, ICIMOD said in a press release here.

The reports call for a massive scale-up in glacier monitoring, better standard-

isation of methodologies, and robust investment in climate-resilient adaptation planning to mitigate the impacts of a rapidly changing cryosphere.

The Himalayan mountain range holds the largest volume of ice outside the poles, the report said, adding that these are also the source

of at least 10 major Asian river systems, supporting the food, water, energy, and livelihood security of billions of people.

Around 78 per cent of this glacier area, located between 4,500 and 6,000 metres above sea level, is highly exposed to elevation-dependent warming, according to the report.

Pema Gyamtsho, Director General of ICIMOD, termed this a crisis unfolding in real time. "The fact that ice loss rates have doubled this century should shock us all into action," he said, adding that the Hindu Kush Himalaya is at a crossroads.

"The rapidly escalating impacts we're seeing from water uncertainty to catastrophic floods underscore that we are in a critical decade for the cryosphere.

We must scale up monitoring and invest in adaptation now. They are our new reality," he said.

The comprehensive analysis reveals that between 1990 and 2020, HKH glaciers lost about 12 per cent of their total area and 9 per cent of their estimated ice reserves, the report highlighted. "But the losses are most acute for the region's smallest glaciers - those below 0.5 sq km - which are shrinking more rapidly than others," said Sudan Maharjan, Remote Sensing Analyst at ICIMOD and lead author of the glacier dynamics report.

"This poses immediate risks of localised water shortages for high mountain communities and intensifies hazards like glacial lake outburst floods," he said. (PTT)



BRIEFLY

FIVB takes charge of VFI with steering committee



The International Volleyball Federation (FIVB) has granted provisional recognition to the Volleyball Federation of India (VFI) while raising concerns with the IOA on the delay in granting visas to athletes for an event conducted this month and pending dues of over Rs three crore from private partners. In three separate letters to Indian Olympic Association (IOA), the FIVB has also formed a steering committee to “ensure institutional coordination between the FIVB, IOA, and the VFI interim leadership, while safeguarding the interests of athletes and ensuring the continuity of national team programmes and international participation.” The recognition to VFI has been granted for eight months and the FIVB said it is being done “solely and exclusively to facilitate the release and utilisation of government funding due to VFI for preparation, training and participation” of Indian teams internationally. The Steering Committee comprises IOA Executive Council member Rohit Rajpal, CEO Raghuram Iyer, FIVB General Sports Director Steve Tutton, FIVB Head of Legal Affairs and General Counsel Stephen Bock and Hitesh Malhotra.Tutton, in a separate letter, has gone on to complain about visa issues faced by unspecified athletes who competed in a Beach Pro Tour competition in Bhubaneswar. Twenty seven men's teams and 22 women's teams from 23 different countries took part in the Bhubaneswar Challenge. Tutton also alleged that the FIVB has still not been paid its dues, which amount to over Rs three crore, for the Pro Tour events held in 2023 and 2024 in Goa and Chennai respectively in partnership with private clubs.

Swimmer McEvoy breaks 50-meter freestyle world record



Olympic and world champion swimmer Cameron McEvoy has broken the men's 50-metre freestyle world record which had stood for 17 years. The 31-year-old Australian posted a time of 20.88 seconds on Friday at the China Open in Shenzhen, taking 0.03 second off Brazilian Cesar Cielo's previous mark. Cielo set his world record of 20.91 during swimming's so-called “super suit” era in 2009. Those suits were later banned because they increased buoyancy and reduced drag, resulting in nearly 150 world records falling in 2009 before being prohibited in 2010. “I knew I had a chance to do a PB (personal best),” McEvoy said. “My old PB was 21.06, so maybe 20.99? But doing 20.88 is unreal. It's crazy.” Cielo was quick to congratulate McEvoy on social media, tweeting: “Congrats, Cam. Lightning fast swim! Incredible!”

Japan wins Women’s Asian Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Sydney

Maika Hamano's first-half strike propelled Japan to the Women's Asian Cup title with a 1-0 win over Australia on Saturday at Sydney's Stadium Australia.

The 21-year-old Hamano, on loan at Tottenham from Chelsea, took a pass from the left with her back to goal, turned and launched a powerful strike from outside the area in the 17th minute.

The Australians applied all the pressure in the last 10 minutes, pressing for an equaliser but were continually denied by Japan's defence, including Alanna Kennedy's close-range header with two minutes left



in regulation.

Japan had beaten Australia in finals to win back-to-back Women's Asian Cups in 2014 and 2018 and has now won the title three

times in the last four continental championships.

The top-ranked team in Asia conceded just one goal in six games in Australia. The Matildas haven't won

the continental championship since 2010, when Sam Kerr — then 16 — scored in the decider.

Six teams from the Asian Cup have qualified for next year's Women's World Cup in Brazil. The 12-team tournament gained global attention due to the involvement of an Iranian squad affected by the Middle East war.

The Iranian team arrived in Australia before the Feb. 28 attacks by the United States and Israel triggered the Iran war, and their participation held the international focus. Seven members of the Iran delegation initially were granted asylum by the Australian government, but all but two have since returned home.

Manchester United draw 2-2 at Bournemouth

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bournemouth

Bruno Fernandes got a goal and an assist and Harry Maguire marked his return to the England squad by getting a red card as Manchester United drew 2-2 at Bournemouth in the Premier League on Friday.

After a dull first half, Fernandes, so often United's saviour, put the visitor ahead from the penalty spot an hour in. Ryan Christie equalized for Bournemouth with a perfectly executed low shot six minutes later.

Fernandes' in-swinging corner was headed into his own goal by James Hill under pressure from Maguire at the far post. Then with 12



minutes remaining Maguire — who hours earlier was named in Thomas Tuchel's squad for pre-World Cup friendlies against Uruguay and Japan — was red-carded for bringing down Evanilson

in the box. Teenage Bournemouth forward Junior Kroupi converted the penalty to make it 2-2. The home side threw everything at its more illustrious visitor during a frantic final push but could

not get a winner. Instead, it was a fifth consecutive draw for the Cherries, whose unbeaten run clicked on to 11 matches.

“I’m happy for the performance — it’s a decent point always when you face United,” Bournemouth coach Andoni Iraola said. “But in the big picture it’s five draws in a row. It doesn’t give you a lot in the standings. Probably, especially at the end, we were looking for a win.” Bournemouth was 10th in the table. United remained in third place, six points behind Manchester City, but captain Fernandes could not hide his disappointment at not taking all three points. “We were in front two times, we gave it away,” he said.

Sungjae Im takes lead into the weekend on the firm and fast Copperhead course

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Palm Harbor (USA)

Sungjae Im held onto the lead on a breezy Friday afternoon in the Valspar Championship, rallying on the back nine to edge ahead of David Lipsky in firm and fast conditions on the Copperhead course at Innisbrook.

After missing two straight cuts in his return from a wrist injury, Im shot a 2-under 69 to get to 9-under 133 — a stroke ahead of Lipsky. On Thursday morning, Im had two eagles in a 64 for a one-shot advantage over Brandt Snedeker. “The important thing, well, the most important thing is that I can get my drives into the fairways,” the

27-year-old South Korean player said through a translator. “If I do that, then I will be able to give myself good chances. There’s just a lot of danger out there on the course.” On Friday, Im had three bogeys and two birdies in a front-nine 37, then birdied the par-5 11th and par-4 12th. He broke a tie for the lead with a 7-foot birdie putt on the par-3 17th. “I want to really focus and be patient because I have a chance this weekend,” Im said. “This weekend, I think the winds are going to blow and the greens are going to get more firm.”

He has two PGA Tour victories, the 2020 Honda Classic and 2021 Shriners Children's Open. Lipsky had a 65, playing in the first group of the day off



the first tee. Winless on PGA Tour, he birdied the first two holes and four of the the first six, added two more on 10 and 11 and parred the final seven. “It was excellent. I

did everything well,” Lipsky said. “Missed it in the right spots, holed the putts early on to get some momentum going. That finishing stretch is obviously tough, so able to

save a couple pars down on 16 and 18 and really kept the round going.”

Chandler Blanchet and Doug Ghim were 7 under. Blanchet closed with a bogey for a 66. Ghim shot 67, making an eagle on the par-5 11th, then giving back the strokes with bogeys on 15 and 16. “Obviously, I wish I would have finished a little bit better,” Ghim said. “Two bad holes doesn’t really necessarily kind of ruin a good day.”

Snedeker had a 72 to drop to 5 under. The 45-year-old US Presidents Cup captain received a sponsor exemption. “The good thing is it’s playing really tough and tricky this afternoon,” Snedeker said. “Try to take a positive from that. Hung in there when

things weren't going great.” Jordan Smith (68) also was 5 under with Matt Fitzpatrick (69), Marco Penge (68) and Alex Smalley (69).

“I definitely hit it better yesterday and putted better today,” Spieth said. “So, just try to put them both together on the weekend.” Fitzpatrick was second last week in The Players Championship. Brooks Koepka was tied for 10th at 4 under after a 67 in his return to Innisbrook. He missed a 3-foot birdie putt on his final hole. “Just keep doing what I’m doing,” Koepka said. “Playing well, like the way I’m striking it.” Defending champion Viktor Hovland missed the cut with rounds of 70 and 75.

Hyo Joo Kim doubles lead to 4 strokes in the Founders Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Menlo Park (USA)

Hyo Joo Kim doubled her lead to four strokes Friday in the Fortinet Founders Cup, capping a late afternoon rally with a 6-foot birdie putt on the par-3 eighth.

A day after holing out for eagle on the par-5 18th hole for a 9-under 63 and a two-shot lead, Kim shot 70 in her afternoon round at tree-lined Sharon Heights.

Gabby Lopez was second at 7 under after a 70 in the morning session, with top-ranked Jeeno Thitikul and Nelly Korda in the group another shot back.

Playing the back nine first Friday, Kim bogeyed Nos. 11 and 17, then rebounded with birdies on 18, 1 and 3 and 8.



“The golf course is a bit hard,” Kim said. “The tee shots are hard to play and the shape of the course is a little tricky. I try my best to just try to do what I need to do.” The South Korean player, ranked eighth in the world, won the 2015 Founders Cup in Phoenix for the second of her seven LPGA Tour titles. “It’s been so

long,” Kim said about the 2015 victory. “I think I won my rookie year. It was an unforgettable memory because it was my first win as a LPGA member.” Coming off a third-place finish last month in Thailand, Kim is the defending champion next week in Arizona in the Ford Championship at Wild Horse Pass. Lopez, from Mexico,

had three front-nine birdies and dropped a stroke on the par-4 16th.

Thitikul rebounded from an opening 72 with a 66 in the afternoon. She opened with a bogey and birdied five of the next seven. On the back nine, she birdied 12 and 18. “You have to be on the fairway first,” Thitikul said. “Find the fairway. The rough was rough.”

Korda, who skipped the Asia swing after winning the season opener in Florida, had a 68 in the morning to get to 6 under. She had late birdies on the Nos. 7 and 8.

“It’s tricky. You really have to shape it out here,” Korda said. “Some of the trees are a little bit intimidating and the greens are tough, too. Not only are they really

undulated, but sometimes they’re a little bit harder to read, too.”

Minjee Lee (70), Aditi Ashok (66), Karis Davidson (68), Hye-Jin Choi (70) and Jin Hee Im (72) also were 6 under. Lee closed with a bogey after making four straight birdies.

“A little bit of things to clean up, but I think I’m in a pretty nice position going into the weekend,” Lee said.

The tournament began as a tribute to the 13 founders of the LPGA. It began in Arizona in 2011 and last year was the second event of the season and played in Florida. It has attracted eight of the top 10 players in the world ranking and kicks off a four-tournament stretch in the West ahead of the first major of the year.

Lens back on top of Ligue 1 thanks to star turn from Florian Thauvin

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Lens

Florian Thauvin scored one and made two and Odsonne Edouard grabbed a double as Lens beat Angers 5-1 to leapfrog Paris Saint-Germain and return to the top of Ligue 1 on Friday.

Lens is seeking a first French title since 1998 but its challenge has faltered in recent weeks with losses to Lorient and Monaco.

However, it made its intentions clear in a comprehensive win over a side that has lost five of its last six league matches. Thauvin set the ball rolling in the 13th minute with his fourth goal in six games. Then he set up



Edouard to make it 2-0. Mamadou Sangare added the third just before halftime.

Edouard scored a fourth three minutes into the second half after taking a perfectly weighted pass from the outstanding Thauvin. Although Lanroy Machine pulled a goal back for Angers 14 minutes later it was no

more than a consolation. Matthieu Udol restored Lens' four-goal cushion with a spectacular fifth.

The result took Lens two points clear of PSG, which has two games in hand. Angers, meanwhile, was in 12th place, far from the fight from European places but well above the relegation zone.

Villarreal overruns Real Sociedad to move into third place in La Liga

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Madrid

Villarreal beat Real Sociedad 3-1 and completed its first La Liga double over the Basque side since 2016-17 on Friday. All of Villarreal's goals came in a busy first half.

Gerard Moreno got the opener with a header after seven minutes, and eight minutes later Georges Mikautadze tapped in a second following good work from midfield by Alberto Moleiro. Nicolas Pepe made it 3-0 midway through the first half when he strode forward and his deflected shot crept past goalkeeper Alex Remiro. Luka Sucic



pulled a goal back for Sociedad in the first minute of the second half but the visitor could not mount a comeback. It remained in seventh place after missing a chance to go equal on points with the team above it, Celta Vigo. Villarreal, meanwhile, moved into

third, a point above Atletico Madrid. Atletico's game in hand is on Sunday at arch-rival Real Madrid.

The win was Villarreal's 12th in 15 games at Estadio de la Ceramica this season, with the only defeats coming at the hands of Real Madrid and Barcelona.

Chennaiyin FC take on FC Goa in first home game

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Chennaiyin FC would look to build on their hard-fought win against rivals Kerala Blasters FC when they host fourth-placed FC Goa in their first home fixture of the Indian Super League here on Sunday. Summer signing Imran Khan's first goal secured Chennaiyin's maiden win of the campaign in their previous outing.

Head coach Clifford Rayes Miranda, speaking ahead of the next fixture, stressed the need for his side to build on that momentum against an opponent that remains unbeaten in the league so far.

“I won't give away the plan, but we try to stop the



opponent as a team and as a group. We don't usually go for man-marking, that is not our style or our way. We work collectively and look to nullify the opposition together, rather than focusing on indi-

viduals, unless it's a set-piece situation,” Miranda said.

He also reflected on the team's progress in settling into their roles and the improvements required in the final third, particularly in

converting promising moments into goals.

“We have been trying various structural adjustments and are working towards consistency in the positions we want to occupy

in the final third. We hope to get that right and start scoring more regularly.

“We have been creating good moments and generating chances, but we need to be more dominant, especially in the final third. We also need to be a bit calmer on the ball, and at times we are slightly tentative, particularly in those key attacking areas,” the head coach added. FC Goa's visit will also be the first time this season Chennaiyin plays in front of a home crowd. The Marina Machans were on the road for the first four games of the campaign, a run which yielded a win and a draw, and will be eager to march towards three more points with their faithful behind their backs.

India to play two T20Is against Ireland

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Reigning world champions India will play two T20 Internationals in Ireland on June 26 and June 28 respectively, the BCCI said on Saturday about the games that will precede their white-ball assignment in England.

Both matches will be held at Belfast, where the Indian team will play for the first time since 2007.

“Team India (Senior Men) will travel to Ireland for a two-match T20I series in June 2026. Having toured Ireland three times in the past eight years (2018, 2022 and 2023). This tour will mark India’s return to Belfast for the first time since 2007,” BCCI secre-



tary Devajit Saikia said in a statement. The BCCI statement comes two days after

Ireland’s director of high performance Graham West confirmed the series while

announcing Paul Stirling’s decision to step down as their T20I captain.

India, who host Afghanistan for a one-off Test and a three-match ODI series ending on June 20, will travel to England for five T20Is and three ODIs from July 1-19.

India have toured Ireland three times in the past seven years, drawing strong crowds at Malahide on the outskirts of Dublin. West had said on Thursday the India series is part of their plans for the upcoming summer.

“With qualification secured for the T20 World Cup in 2028, Paul’s (Stirling) decision to stand down as T20 captain provides the opportunity for the new captain to begin implementing their style and methodology, starting with the India series in June,” West had said.

Karnataka’s Tumakuru to host first ITF Women’s W35 tournament

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

In a significant boost to Karnataka’s growing tennis stature, Tumakuru is set to host its first ever ITF Women’s World Tennis Tour W35 tournament from May 4-10. The tournament will be held at the Tumkur District Tennis Stadium, Tumkur University Campus.

The upcoming W35 will be the second international event in Tumakuru’s history and the first ever ITF Women’s tournament in over two decades. The USD 30,000 event is part of the global ITF Women’s circuit, offering a pathway for players to earn professional



ranking points and progress towards the WTA Tour.

Emerging international players and top Indian professionals will compete across a 32-player singles main draw and qualifying rounds. Following a suc-

cessful run of international tournaments in Bengaluru and Kalaburagi, the event strengthens Karnataka’s presence on the global tennis calendar and reflects efforts to take the sport beyond established centres.

Manav, Yashaswini win maiden national TT crowns



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Indore

Petroleum Sports Promotion Board (PSPB) paddlers Manav Thakkar and Yashaswini Ghorpade clinched their maiden singles titles at the Senior National Table Tennis Championships on Saturday. In the men’s final, top seed Manav lived up to the expectations with a commanding 4-1 (11-2, 11-4, 6-11, 11-9, 11-3) victory over Jeet Chandra of the Railway Sports Promotion Board (RSPB).

The PSPB star dominated from the outset, racing through the opening two games with ease. Although Jeet briefly pushed back to take the third game, he struggled to replicate the sharp form that carried him through the semifinals.

Manav quickly regained control, sealing the contest 11-3 in the fifth game to cap off an emphatic title run.

The women’s final delivered everything you’d expect from a title clash — intensity, momentum swings, and a finish that kept everyone on edge till the very last point.

Finally, Yashaswini etched

her name into the record books, clinching the title with a hard-fought 4-3 (11-6, 12-14, 11-5, 9-11, 13-11, 6-11, 11-8) victory over the young and fearless Syndrelda Das of PSPB.

Yashaswini started with authority, taking the opening game 11-6, but the 16-year-old Das quickly showed she was no pushover. She edged a tense second game 14-12, setting the tone for what would become a see-saw battle. The two traded blows through the middle phase but Yashaswini’s controlled aggression earned her the third, and Syndrelda responded with resilience to claim the fourth. Yashaswini inched ahead again with a narrow 13-11 fifth game, but Das refused to fade, dominating the sixth 11-6 to force a decider.

With the title on the line, it was Yashaswini’s composure that made the difference. She held her nerve in crucial rallies, closing out the final game 11-8 to seal a memorable victory. For Yashaswini, this triumph marks a breakthrough moment — a first championship earned through grit and consistency under pressure.

Ghosal terms squash’s inclusion in Olympics watershed moment

HIMANK NEGI/
SANSKRITI GAUBA
■ New Delhi

Former India number 1 Saurav Ghosal termed squash’s inclusion in the 2028 Olympics a watershed moment and emphasised the need to expand access, improve coaching, and strengthen the ecosystem to sustain the sport’s growth. Recently appointed Sports Commissioner of World Premier Squash, Ghosal said the role is a culmination of his journey in the sport.

“I played professional squash and for India for more than 20 years... it’s been a blessing. This phase is a coming together of all those experiences and I’m

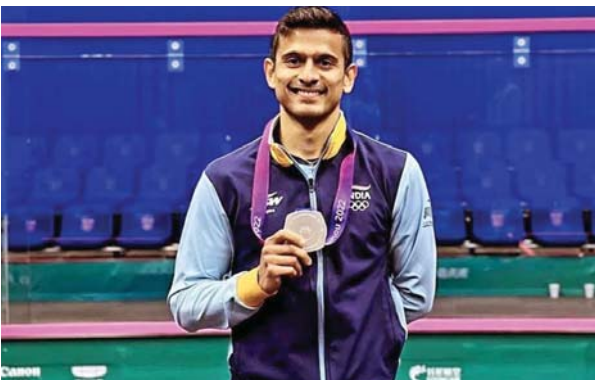
excited to hopefully make a contribution at the global level and democratise the sport,” he said.

“I’ve always viewed pressure situations as opportunities... this is an opportunity to do something substantial in the sport,” he added.

On India’s rise in squash, Ghosal underlined the importance of participation.

“Strength lies in numbers... if you have more players playing, the probability is that you will produce champions,” he said.

“The upward trajectory is very heartening... and this is an attempt to democratise the sport, get more kids, more people and recreational players involved because the entire ecosystem has to



be involved,” he added.

He also highlighted the role of exposure and opportunity. “There are so many players who haven’t had the financial backing or the right guidance. This can give them a window to showcase their

talent on the world stage,” he said. India currently has multiple players in the top-50, including teenager Anahat Singh. “It’s great that we have four boys in the top-50, we also have Anahat in the top-20. Success breeds

Star-studded Hero Indian Open 2026 to feature five top-100 players

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gurugram

Five players from the world’s top-100 and several World Tour champions will line up at the Hero Indian Open, making the 2026 edition one of the strongest fields at the DLF Golf and Country Club from March 26-29.

The world-class field will be starred by Akshay Bhatia, currently ranked 22 in the world and a recent winner on the PGA Tour, and Italy’s Francesco Molinari, the 2018 Open champion and a three-time Ryder Cup winner.

Besides Bhatia, the other players in the top-100 include Casey Jarvis (69), Elvis Smylie (74), David Puig (85) and Thriston Lawrence (89). Jarvis



has been in red-hot form, clinching back-to-back titles earlier this season — the Investec South African Open and the Magical Kenya Open in successive weeks.

Defending champion

Eugenio Chacarra, currently ranked 143, leads a group of eight players placed between 101 and 150.

The others are Angel Ayora, Andy Sullivan, Nacho Elvira, Dan Bradbury, Calum

Hill, Martin Couvra and Julien Guerrier. The home challenge will be spearheaded by Shubhankar Sharma, a two-time DP World Tour winner, along with Yuvraj Sandhu, winner of the 2025 PGTI Order of Merit, previous PGTI OOM winners, Manu Gandas, Om Prakash Chouhan and Veer Ahlawat, who in 2024 finished runner-up at the Hero Indian Open and Rayhan Thomas.

The local contingent will also include multiple winners on the PGTI like Shaurya Bhattacharya, Sri Lankan N Thangaraja, Honey Baisoya, Khalin Joshi and Saptak Talwar, among others. The field will also see two rising stars of Indian golf — 16-year old Kartik

Singh and 21-year-old Shubham Jaglan, who have been given sponsor invitations for the tournament.

Several other players arrive in strong form. Apart from Jarvis, Bradbury, Freddy Schott, Elvira and Puig, who have won in the current 2026 season.

Another seven players won in 2025 and as many as a dozen players were successful in 2024, making the current gathering as one of the most decorated fields.

Additionally, there are numerous experienced DPWT winners like Rafa Cabrera Bello, Matteo Manassero, Joost Luiten, Jorge Campillo, Kiradech Aphibarnrat, Ross Fisher, Bernd Wiesberger, and

others. With the cut-off to retain a full card through the Race to Dubai rankings reduced from the top 110 to top 100, the fight for points and the Tour cards has become closer.

Hence, the tournament will see intense competition as the players battle it out for money and points. Co-sanctioned by the Indian Golf Union and part of the DP World Tour, the tournament will offer a record prize purse of \$2.55 million.

Began in 1964, the Hero Indian Open is the country’s oldest international professional golf event and has been co-sanctioned by the DP World Tour since 2015. Entry for spectators will be free across all four days.

Kohli urges RCB teammates not to waste any training session

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Talismanic batter Virat Kohli on Saturday urged his Royal Challengers Bengaluru teammates to “switch on” themselves and not waste even a minute at the training sessions as they gear up for their IPL title defence.

Addressing the squad during their first practice session at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium, Kohli underlined the need to maintain the intensity that brought them the title last year. “We worked really hard over the last two to three seasons to achieve what we did last year, and it’s only going to get tougher because other teams are going to come hard at us,” Kohli said.



RCB will open their IPL 2026 campaign against Sunrisers Hyderabad on March 28 at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium.

Emphasising urgency from day one, he added, “We don’t waste these days. We stay ahead. So, switch on now. Let’s not waste even a minute of any session that we are a

part of. We must give our 120 per cent for these two and a half months.”

RCB added Venkatesh Iyer, Mangesh Yadav, Jordan Cox, Vicky Ostwal and Satvik Deswal to their squad at the auction. Head coach Andy Flower expressed satisfaction with the squad assem-

bled after the auction, saying the franchise had strengthened key areas. “We had an interesting auction and I think we’ve improved our squad, to be quite frank. We’ve brought in some great new additions. Integrating them into the RCB way along-side established players led by Virat and Rajat is an exciting part of building this team,” Flower said.

Highlighting the significance of being reigning champions, Flower said the team would embrace the challenge rather than dwell on past success.

“There is one difference this year, we’ve got a star on our shirt. That’s a very proud feeling for all RCB fans. But that season is gone. Now we have a new challenge ahead,

and it’s an exciting one. We’re here to win this year’s IPL,” he added.

Wicketkeeper-batter Jitesh Sharma spoke about the positive atmosphere within the group as new and old members came together.

“Everyone was very excited to meet each other. I was excited to get more batting time. I got a chance to meet all the coaches and train again,” he said.

Flower also pointed to the advantage of beginning their campaign at home.

“Our first game is here at Chinnaswamy, which is a fantastic opportunity for us to build momentum early and be welcomed by our home fans. The outfield is looking superb, lush, green and beautiful,” he said.

Wimbledon introduces video review on six courts for this year’s tournament

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Wimbledon will use video review technology for the first time at this year’s tournament, the All England Club announced Saturday.

The oldest Grand Slam tennis tournament will have the technology available on Centre Court, No. 1 Court — the club’s second-biggest stadium — plus four other show courts.

Players will be allowed to review specific calls made by the chair umpire — such as double bounces.

Video review made its Grand Slam tennis debut at the 2023 US Open. The Australian Open also uses



the technology. Centre Court and No. 1 Court will have video review available throughout the tournament, which starts on June 29, and the technology will be used on No. 2 Court, No. 3 Court, Court 12 and Court 18 for singles matches.

Players will not be limited

in the number of reviews they can request.

Video review is separate from the electronic line-calling used for ruling balls in or out. Last year, Wimbledon replaced line judges with electronic line-calling, though it wasn’t without hiccups.

Akash Deep out of IPL with back injury; doubtful for one-off Test against Afghanistan in June

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders suffered yet another blow to their pace resources with India seamer Akash Deep ruled out for at least eight weeks due to a stress reaction in his lower back on Saturday, which effectively sidelined him from the Indian Premier League.

The injury has also put the right-arm pacer in serious doubt for the one-off Test against Afghanistan in early June. “Akash Deep has had a stress reaction on his lower back. There has been recurrence and it might take 8-12 weeks to heal. He is not going to play the IPL and is very unlikely to be selected

against Afghanistan,” a BCCI source in the know told PTL.

The 29-year-old Bengal pacer, who was last seen in action during the Ranji Trophy semifinal against Jammu and Kashmir, had looked short of full fitness, bowling just 13 overs in the first innings and under seven in the second.

He has since been undergoing rehabilitation at the BCCI Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru and did not join KKR preparatory camp which began here on Wednesday.

“It will take considerable time for healing and workload adaptation followed by return-to-play protocols. So conservative estimate of recovery will be around 10 weeks but it could take more



time,” the board source added. Akash Deep is the latest addition to the three-time champions’ growing injury list which includes

India pacer Harshit Rana and their 18-crore Sri Lankan recruit Matheesha Pathirana, further depleting the franchise’s fast-bowling stocks.

With Akash Deep and Rana unavailable, KKR will have to rely heavily on their remaining domestic options, including Vaibhav Arora, Kartik

Tyagi and a fit-again Umran Malik. KKR, who finished a poor eighth in their title defence last season, are already without Rana, who is recovering from a ligament strain in his right knee.

The left-arm seamer Mustafizur Rahman had to be released earlier this year following a BCCI directive, prompting KKR to rope in Zimbabwe quick Blessing Muzarabani as his replacement. The Abhishek Nayarch-coached and Ajinkya Rahane-led franchise has also been scouting replacements and held trials featuring several IPL-experienced pacers, including Akash Madhwal, Navdeep Saini, Simarjeet Singh, KM Asif and Sandeep Warrier. Among them,

Madhwal, who grabbed attention with a stunning 5/5 for Mumbai Indians in the 2023 Eliminator, appears to be ahead in the race, though the franchise is yet to announce a replacement.

Nayar on Friday said the management is close to finalising a replacement and would do it before leaving for their IPL opener in Mumbai on April 29.

The squad will leave for Mumbai on April 25. “It (Harshit Rana’s absence) is a big blow because Harshit has been an integral part of this team for the last couple of seasons, also the championship season. Over the last year, he’s really grown as a cricketer. So we always miss Harshit Rana.”

“But having said that, over the last few days, we’ve been looking at a few bowlers, we’ve had to evaluate with the help of our leadership group as to who fits in and who can do that role to the best of their prowess. Hopefully we’ll identify someone who we feel can make a difference,” Nayar said.

However, team mentor Dwayne Bravo does not believe it’s a worry and insisted that they have enough depth to cope with the setbacks. “In any tournament with any team, once you lose some of the key bowling options, these are not things you plan for, but these are things you have to accept,” Bravo said on Friday.

SAKSHI PRIYA

The internet never stops comparing 2026 to 2016. The sudden album drops and wild pop culture drama certainly make that argument believable. But look at what everyone is actually wearing on the street right now. Fashion completely missed that memo. The industry skipped right over it and dove headfirst into 1996 instead. It is getting hot outside, but nobody cares about those clean, boring, minimalist clothes

anymore. They are getting shoved straight to the back of the closet. Sure, the fashion crowd is always stealing from the 90s. We know that. Honestly, it just looks like people are finally having getting dressed again.

Retail analysts tracking buyer habits are seeing a massive shift in the numbers. It turns out this whole 90s takeover is definitely not an accident. Search data across major fashion platforms shows a ridiculous spike in terms like bias-cut and parachute fabric since early spring. People are loudly voting with their wallets. They absolutely refuse to buy anything tight or restrictive for the upcoming heatwave. Just grab a seat outside any cafe. The slip dress is literally everywhere. Tight clothes are done. People want room to breathe. You see these lightweight silk midi dresses tossed over basic white baby tees all over the city. Throw on some chunky platform sandals, and it just works. It looks like a lazy Sunday morning, but it survives the midday heat.

Look around, and the long, flowing maxi skirt is practically everywhere. Shoppers grab these swishy pieces and throw them on with basic ribbed vests, hitting that relaxed, unbothered 90s vibe right on the head. To finish it off, a printed silk scarf is usually tied tightly at the collarbone or wrapped through the hair. That specific formula, long skirt, blank tank, bright scarf, is incredibly basic, but it absolutely refuses to fail on a sweltering afternoon. The babydoll dress is crashing back, too. Ditsy, chaotic floral prints are currently hijacking the racks. Those high empire waists and puffed sleeves physically refuse to stick to sweating skin. But the styling is where the rebellion happens. Nobody wears them neatly. Take a moody, dark floral version and knot a massive, faded flannel shirt right at the hips. It destroys the sweetness. It is sloppy. It is comfortable. Pure grunge perfection for a weekend brunch.

Sturdy denim trousers are officially off the table. The style crowd surrendered to slouchy, breathable cuts weeks ago. The hunt for the perfect midi-length denim skirt has turned into a total obsession. Everyone is chasing the same detail right now. They want that deep front slit to catch

whatever breeze is left in the city. Pairing that stiff, rugged fabric with a minimal cropped halter top solves everything. It is the absolute fastest way to put together an outfit that handles the midday glare without completely falling apart.

The men are reading from the same script. Men finally dropped those suffocating slim-fit trousers they clung to for way too long. Shop windows are filled with oversized, baggy skater shorts pooling over chunky trainers. Walk past any local spot, and it is a total Britpop revival. An unbuttoned, short-sleeve bowling shirt thrown over a plain white vest is the new default. It handles the sticky humidity without falling apart.

Keep the layers incredibly loose and let the throwback mood run the show. You want a bias-cut slip dress or a ditsy floral maxi dress paired up with seriously heavy sandals. Tie a printed scarf at the throat, surrender to the baggy cuts, and let 1996 on the streets. We are officially dropping stiff, miserable fabrics for something completely fresh straight from the archives. The only real question left is, which vintage rack are you raiding first this weekend?

The scorching heatwave has arrived and modern minimalism is officially dead. Welcome to the loud, unbothered 1996 summer fashion revival

TEAM VIVA

Let's be real. The second the summer heat hits, those grand fashion plans melt straight into the pavement. Getting through the morning traffic without dying of heat completely takes over your day. You spot a pair of thick sneakers by the door? Absolutely not. Come on. Sweating through your socks before 10 AM? Hard pass. We really just need some kind of sweet spot between suffocating closed leather shoes and giving up completely in bathroom slippers. This season is about outsmarting the heat: breathable mesh, zero blisters, and effortless slip-ons. Grab an iced coffee and build your summer shoe survival kit.

We once mocked those chunky tourist straps. Now? The joke's ours. They've returned, refined with leather and sleek metal. If your day requires a city-wide sprint, this level of comfort feels absolutely essential.



want a softer look? Activities are having a moment. Thankfully, we're skipping those intense, calf-strangling gladiator straps from a few years ago. A delicate cord wrapped once or twice looks perfectly sharp under wide-leg trousers.

Ballet flats are still everywhere. Trapping your toes in stiff leather during a heatwave, though? Absolute nightmare. Swap them for mesh instead. Keep that polished aesthetic, but let your feet breathe. They transition easily from work to cold coffee.



Forget those boring white or black shoes. This buttery mocha brown is easily the best neutral for the heat. It grounds your look perfectly. Pair them with loose linen pants or old jeans. These slides always look surprisingly expensive, no matter the price. That square toe detail makes them very 2026.



*A designer captures his
parents holding each
other in leather form*

SAKSHI PRIYA



Artisans down in Jaipur handcrafted all the sculptural brass hardware for the collection. The design team then paired that heavy metalwork with quilted leathers, rich

velvets, and bespoke suede interiors. He specifically focused on materials built to handle real daily life. The goal is for people to carry them season after season, avoiding items that get forgotten in a closet after a few months. A handbag finally lets people bring a small piece of the Valaya world into a totally regular Tuesday. You can throw on a completely basic outfit and still hold that high-end luxury right in your hand.

The larger Jagjit bag acts as a protective shell, with the smaller Raj bag nestled inside. Together, they look like an embrace. It felt symbolic. My father was an army man – he was all about strength and discipline. My mother was warmth and grace. The design just reflects that balance between them.

JJ VALAYA

TEAM VIVA

The seventh edition of the Habitat International Film Festival 2026 is currently underway at the India Habitat Centre, drawing enthusiastic crowds of cinephiles, students, and critics from across the capital. The festival has once again turned Delhi into a vibrant hub of global cinema and cultural dialogue.

This year's festival features an expansive line-up of 67 films from 18 countries, spanning award-winning contemporary cinema, restored classics, retrospectives, and emerging voices. The curatorial theme emphasises storytelling around identity, memory, and displacement, resonating strongly with audiences navigating a rapidly changing world.

its focus on Hungarian cinema, with over 20 films showcasing the works of renowned filmmakers such as István Szabó and Zoltán Fábri. In addition, a special retrospective marks the birth centenary of legendary Polish director Andrzej Wajda, adding historical depth to the contemporary line-up.

Festival venues, including the Stein Auditorium and other screening spaces within the Habitat Centre, have witnessed packed houses and long queues, particularly for evening screenings and critically acclaimed titles. With many screenings offered on a first-come, first-served basis, attendees have been arriving well in advance to secure seats—reflecting the festival's growing popularity among Delhi's film-loving community.

Audience response has been notably diverse. Young viewers and film students have been drawn to experimental and international entries, while older audiences have shown keen interest in retrospectives and restored classics. Conversations spilling out of screening halls-ranging from cinematic techniques to socio-political themes-have become a defining feature of the festival atmosphere.

HIFF 2026 continues to position itself as more than just a film showcase. With nearly 24 films directed by women, the festival

THE DOG AND I

TEAM VIVA

Shruti Gupta Chandra has made a powerful return to Sridharani after fifteen years. Her latest solo show, *Where does the mind stop and the world begin*, ditches her familiar realism for a raw, untethered abstraction. Working with curator Ashwini Pai Bahadur, Chandra draws on four decades of Kathak dance to treat her canvases like a stage. You see this in the “desire paths,” instinctive markings cutting across white space. Forms look like spinning figures caught in a blur, with scratched pigment revealing thin lines beneath. Including notes from art historian Lina Vincent, the exhibition stays on view through March 24.



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The Pioneer AGENDA

We must clean our national psyche from all manifestation of evil, be it kidnapping, militancy, insurgency or assassinations
— Sunday Adelaja



GREY-ZONE INTRUSIONS

Is the Northeast becoming the hotbed of foreign operations?

The arrest of American national Matthew Aaron VanDyke and several Ukrainian citizens by India's National Investigation Agency has cast a sharp light on a shadowy network operating along the Indo-Myanmar border. What appears at first to be an isolated case of foreign involvement may, in fact, signal a deeper and more complex convergence of insurgency, geopolitics, and covert influence in India's Northeast

The rising security challenges in Northeast India

The recent arrest of American national Matthew Aaron VanDyke and six Ukrainian citizens by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) has exposed a sophisticated grey-zone network operating along the Indo-Myanmar border. Charged under Section 18 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), the group is accused of training Myanmar-based Ethnic Armed Groups (EAGs) and coordinating the illegal import of drone technology-activities that the NIA claims directly threaten India's internal security and sovereignty.

Who is Matthew VanDyke? From "Documentary Filmmaker" to Mercenary Matthew VanDyke is not a typical NGO activist. His trajectory reflects the evolution of the modern "independent" combatant who blurs the lines between journalism, activism, and private military contracting.

Between 2011 and 2013, VanDyke gained international notoriety during the Libyan Civil War, where he transitioned from a filmmaker to an armed rebel fighter against Muammar Gaddafi. He was captured and spent nearly six months in a prison in Tripoli. Later, he appeared in Syria, ostensibly to film, but admitted to advising rebel groups.

In 2014, VanDyke founded Sons of Liberty International (SOLI), which he describes as a



BHASKAR JYOTI MAHANTA
Former DGP of Assam

non-profit security organisation. Unlike traditional private military companies such as Blackwater, SOLI claims to provide military training and tactical advice to "oppressed" groups free of cost, funded through private donations.

In 2025, VanDyke claimed on social media to have been running covert operations with Venezuelan rebels since 2019. His arrest in India suggests a shift in focus towards the Myanmar conflict, leveraging the vacuum created by instability following the 2021 military coup.

The NIA's investigation reveals a methodical breach of Indian border protocols to facilitate insurgent support. The group, comprising VanDyke and 14 Ukrainians (seven of whom are still being tracked), reportedly entered India on tourist visas. This "hiding in plain sight" tactic enabled them to move through major hubs such as Delhi, Lucknow, and Kolkata before converging in the Northeast.

The accused allegedly bypassed the mandatory Protected Area Permit (PAP) to enter Mizoram. From there, they are believed to have crossed the porous 1,643-km border into Myanmar. A central pillar of the NIA's case is the alleged illegal shipment of drones from Europe via India. In modern guerrilla warfare, drones function as "force multipliers", used for surveillance and improvised explosive device (IED) delivery. Supplying such technology to Myanmar-based EAGs-many of whom share ethnic ties and logistical routes with Indian insurgent groups-creates a direct security risk for Indian forces.

Against this backdrop, the recent influx of thousands of Myanmar nationals warrants closer examination. The arrival of Chin refugees in Mizoram has reinvigorated discourse around Zo reunification-the idea of unifying Mizo, Chin, and Kuki communities. Rooted in shared Tibeto-Burman ancestry and a common Christian identity, this movement has evolved from a fringe cultural aspiration into a central element of regional political rhetoric. Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma has been particularly

vocal, taking the issue to international platforms. During his 2024 visit to the United States, he called for the unification of the "Zo" people under a single administrative framework, arguing that colonial-era borders have unjustly divided a single nation. This position echoes that of his predecessor Zoramthanga, who frequently invoked the "same womb" (chhul khat chhuak) philosophy to justify extending sanctuary to Myanmar's Chin and Manipur's Kuki populations, often in defiance of central directives.

The narrative of a "unified Christian state" has attracted intense scrutiny, particularly regarding possible Western influence. Some analysts argue that a unified "Zo-land" could serve as a pro-Western buffer zone between India, China, and Myanmar's military regime. Concerns have also emerged about potential extra-territorial loyalties. Allegations-though contested-suggest that Western agencies may view the Chin-Kuki-Mizo belt as a strategic foothold to counter Chinese influence in Myanmar's Sagaing Division and the Bay of Bengal.

The Government of India views these "Greater Mizoram" aspirations with caution, as they could challenge the territorial integrity of Manipur, Tripura, and Assam, complicating New Delhi's Act East Policy and its delicate engagement with Myanmar's military establishment. While the movement is rooted in genuine ethnic solidarity, its intersection with global power dynamics has turned it into a sensitive geopolitical flashpoint in Northeast India. The presence of a high-profile American "security analyst" alongside Ukrainian nationals-at a time when Ukraine remains central to global intelligence activity-raises further questions about the possible role of foreign agencies. Mercenaries like VanDyke can function as "deniable assets", advancing the strategic inter-

ests of external powers without formal state involvement.

The involvement of Ukrainian nationals also suggests the transfer of battle-hardened expertise. With the ongoing war in Ukraine serving as a testing ground for advanced drone warfare, the potential migration of such skills to the Myanmar theatre is a significant concern for Indian agencies.

While the US Embassy has maintained a "no comment" stance, there are indications that Russian intelligence may have shared inputs with India-possibly to counter Western influence in the region and safeguard its strategic interests, including defence ties with Myanmar's military.

The involvement of foreign nationals using advanced technology under the guise of activism or documentary filmmaking presents a complex legal and diplomatic challenge. For India, tightening border management remains a priority. Re-evaluating the Free Movement Regime (FMR) and strictly enforcing PAP and Restricted Area Permit (RAP) norms are now key focus areas.

Equally important is tracking the technological supply chain-particularly drone components entering through civilian channels-to ensure that India's sensitive border regions do not become arenas for international proxy conflicts.

The NIA's ongoing probe into the masterminds and funding sources behind this network will be crucial in determining whether this was an isolated operation or part of a broader, coordinated effort to reshape the geopolitics of the Bay of Bengal region.

(The author is presently the General Secretary of the think tank SHARE)

Key facts about the Indo-Myanmar border

- The Indo-Myanmar border is 1,643 km long.
- India shares this border across four northeastern states: Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, and Mizoram.
- Security challenge driven by ethno-nationalist movements, porous terrain, and geopolitical instability within Myanmar.
- These risks have increased significantly since the 2021 military coup.
- Over 64,000 people have crossed the India-Myanmar border into India seeking refuge since the February 2021 military coup.

NE: THE ROOTS OF INSURGENCY

Insurgency in India's Northeast has been one of the most complex internal security challenges since Independence. Rooted in issues of identity, autonomy, and ethnic assertion the region witnessed multiple armed movements across states such as Nagaland, Assam, Manipur, Tripura, and Mizoram.

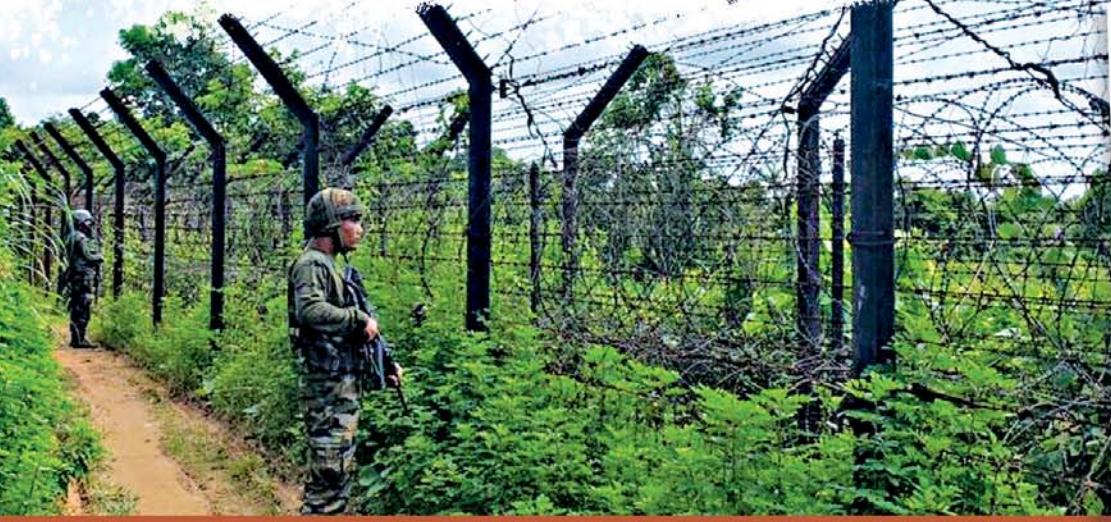
Naga insurgency: The earliest and most influential of these was led by the Naga National Council, which declared independence in 1947, setting the stage for decades of conflict.

Multiple groups emerge: Over time, other groups emerged, including the Mizo National Front, the United Liberation Front of Asom, and the National Socialist Council of Nagaland, each articulating distinct political and ethnic demands.

Mizoram Peace Accord: The insurgencies were marked by cycles of violence, counter-insurgency operations, and political negotiations. The movements, led by MNF, culminated successfully in the Mizoram Peace Accord, leading to lasting peace.

The transformation: Over the past two decades, a combination of sustained security operations, peace talks, economic development initiatives, and improved connectivity has led to a marked decline in violence.

Key agreements, such as the 1997 ceasefire with NSCN (IM), and Bodo accords and peace deals with various militant factions have reduced tensions in Assam.



THE CROSS-BORDER LINKAGES OF INSURGENTS

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

Matthew VanDyke, the filmmaker-turned-mercenary whose Myanmar gambit has just landed him in an Indian jail. His arrest has exposed a new threat to India's sensitive Northeast region. Matthew Aaron VanDyke is the archetype of the 21st-century self-proclaimed 'freedom fighter' who markets himself as a documentarian and activist while quietly building a career as a combatant-for-hire. VanDyke's trajectory is a textbook evolution from observer to operator. Between 2011 and 2013, he gained

fame as a war correspondent in Libya, where he abandoned the camera, joined anti-Gaddafi rebels, was captured, and spent six months in a Tripoli prison. After his release, he surfaced in Syria to advise rebels while still claiming journalistic cover.

In 2014, he formalised the business model by founding Sons of Liberty International (SOLI), a self-described non-profit security firm that offers free military training, tactical advice, and equipment to 'oppressed' groups, funded by private donations. Internal security experts say SOLI wraps its operations in the language of humanitarian intervention and anti-authoritarianism.

It does not charge governments like public management consultants. By 2025, VanDyke was openly boasting on social media of running covert operations with Venezuelan rebels since 2019, including missions later publicised as "Operation Aurora". In early 2026, he simply pivoted theatres: from Caracas to the Myanmar civil war. The NIA alleges he and his Ukrainian team had been making repeated trips since 2024, training Ethnic Armed Organisations (EAOs) in drone strikes, weapons handling, and electronic warfare-capabilities that have transformed Myanmar's battlefield.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

Many former insurgent groups have either disbanded, entered ceasefire arrangements, or joined mainstream politics. States like Tripura and Mizoram are largely peaceful, while Assam has seen a sharp drop in militant activity. Nonetheless, challenges remain, particularly in parts of Manipur and along the India-Myanmar border

Witnessing Kazakhstan's historic referendum



I returned soon after referendum over in Kazakhstan (Astana) from a long circuit of polling stations across Kazakhstan, carrying with me not just notes and numbers, but impressions of a nation at a crossroads. The chill of early spring lingered in the air as voters, many wrapped in heavy coats, queued patiently to cast their ballots. There was no frenzy, no overt tension — just a steady, deliberate rhythm that seemed to mirror the tone of the referendum itself, controlled, significant, and quietly consequential.

By the time the final ballots were counted, the outcome was no surprise. Preliminary figures from the Central Electoral Commission indicated that over 70 percent of eligible voters had participated, with nearly 90 percent endorsing a sweeping new constitution. Later that evening, President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev addressed the nation, declaring the vote a historic turning point. For the government, the message was clear: this was a decisive mandate for change.

Yet on the ground, the story felt more layered.

What comes next

The new constitution is scheduled to come into force on July 1. Before that, the current parliament must pass enabling legislation, after which it will be dissolved. Fresh elections are expected later this year, marking the next phase of this political transition.

For now, the official narrative emphasizes unity, reform, and forward momentum. The numbers support that story. But numbers alone rarely capture the full complexity of political change.

As I prepared to leave the capital, I found myself reflecting less on the scale of the victory and more on its implications. Constitutions are not merely documents; they are living frameworks that shape how power is exercised and contested.

Kazakhstan has, without question, entered a new chapter. Whether this chapter leads to institutional evolution or deeper centralisation will depend not on the text itself, but on how it is implemented.

From New Delhi, the referendum may appear decisive and orderly. On the ground, it felt more nuanced — a moment of transformation, certainly, but one whose true meaning will only emerge with time.

For now, what remains is the image of those long, quiet queues, and the sense that history, even when it appears settled, often unfolds in ways that are anything but predictable.

Contrasts at the ballot, Kazakhstan and India

From the capital to smaller provincial towns across Kazakhstan, polling stations operated with a quiet, almost clinical efficiency. Election offi-

cials worked under bright fluorescent lights, carefully verifying identities and guiding voters through the process with minimal delay.

For an observer from India, the contrast was immediately striking. Indian elections are often defined by their scale and energy—long queues winding through streets, animated political discussions, and a palpable sense of competition. Here, there were no such extended lines. Instead, in the lingering spring chill, voters arrived in short, steady intervals. Small queues formed briefly and dissolved just as quickly, shaped as much by the cold weather as by the streamlined process.

Yet the absence of long queues did not signal disengagement. People still turned out, wrapped in coats against the cold, to participate in what was framed as a decisive moment for constitutional change. The atmosphere, however, remained subdued. Conversations were muted, and there was little of the charged intensity that typically accompanies elections in India.

Several voters expressed cautious optimism, speaking of stability and the impor-



ance of a strong state in uncertain times. Others, in quieter tones, acknowledged that the outcome felt largely predetermined. There was participation, certainly — but not the kind of visible contestation that defines democratic exercises in India. It is within this contrast — between participation and competition — that the deeper meaning of the referendum begins to take shape.



Redrawing the architecture of power

At the heart of the vote lies a fundamental restructuring of Kazakhstan's political system. The new constitution significantly enhances presidential authority, granting the executive broader influence over key

institutions.

Under the revised framework, the president will have expanded powers to appoint senior officials, including judicial and electoral authorities. These appointments will require approval from a newly restructured unicameral parliament, the Kurultai. However, if the parliament rejects nominees twice, it risks dissolution — a provision that effectively strengthens the president's hand.

In such a scenario, the president would also gain the authority to issue decrees carrying the force of law, at least temporarily. Supporters argue this ensures governance continuity. Critics see it as a mechanism that tilts the balance of power decisively toward the executive.

Institutional shifts and political signals

The changes do not stop there. The constitution reshapes the legislature into a single chamber and introduces a new advisory body, the People's Council, whose members will be appointed entirely by the president. While framed as a mechanism for broader consultation, its structure raises questions about independence.

The revival of the vice presidency — absent since the 1990s — is another notable feature. Though the role includes representing the country internationally and stepping in for the president when required, its precise powers remain loosely defined. In practice, much will

depend on how the office is used — and by whom. Taken together, these reforms signal a clear trend: consolidation at the center, even as institutional forms evolve.

Context matters

This referendum does not exist in isolation. It is the second major constitutional overhaul in just four years, unfolding against a backdrop of economic strain and lingering political memory. Inflation has weighed heavily on ordinary citizens, while the unrest of 2022 still casts a long shadow over the national psyche.

For many, stability is not an abstract ideal but a pressing necessity. The government has framed the reforms in precisely these terms — arguing that a stronger executive is essential in a volatile geopolitical environment.

Kazakhstan occupies a strategic position between major powers, including Russia and China. Regional tensions, particularly those linked to the war in Ukraine, have heightened the sense of uncertainty. In this context, the leadership's emphasis on centralized authority is presented as pragmatic rather than ideological.

A managed mandate?

Yet the process itself raises important questions. Opposition voices were notably subdued in the lead-up to the vote, with limited scope for public debate or organised dissent. The campaign period lacked the vibrancy typically associated with transformative political decisions.

As a result, while the numbers point to overwhelming approval, the depth of that support remains open to interpretation. Is this a genuine groundswell of public endorsement, or a reflection of a tightly managed political environment?

From my vantage point at polling stations, the answer seemed somewhere in between. Participation was real. Engagement, however, appeared restrained.

A regional pattern

Kazakhstan's trajectory is not unique. Across parts of Eurasia, constitutional reforms have often served as instruments for redefining political systems without necessarily expanding pluralism. Leadership-driven change, rather than bottom-up transformation, has been the dominant model.

President Tokayev, currently serving a single seven-year term set to run until 2029, has positioned these reforms as part of a term modernisation effort. Analysts suggest the new framework could offer flexibility for future political arrangements, even if no immediate changes to term limits have been announced.

The writer is an Associate Editor (Foreign Affairs) at *The Pioneer*. He recently visited Kazakhstan.

FROM AGENDA COVER

The cross-border linkages of insurgents

Indian investigators further claim the network maintained links with banned Indian insurgent outfits operating in the Northeast.

How VanDyke's Myanmar Presence Directly Undermines India's Internal Security

This is not abstract foreign adventurism; it is a direct vector into India's most volatile region. The India-Myanmar border—especially the 510-km Mizoram stretch—is notoriously porous, with free movement regimes, ethnic kinship across the line (Chin, Mizo, Naga communities), and a history of insurgent safe havens. VanDyke's alleged operation exploited exactly that corridor:

Technology proliferation: Drones and jamming gear routed through Europe, transited via Indian territory, and handed to Myanmar EAOs can easily flow back into Indian insurgent hands. Northeast groups have already begun experimenting with commercial drones for reconnaissance and IED delivery; professional training from ex-Libya, Ukraine, and now Myanmar operators accelerates that lethal learning curve.

Cross-border insurgent linkage: The NIA explicitly states the trainees included "banned outfits operating within India". Manipur's ethnic clashes, Assam's residual ULFA factions, and Naga splin-



ter groups have long drawn ideological and logistical oxygen from Myanmar's war economy. Training camps just across the border become exportable skill sets and exportable fighters.

Erosion of border sovereignty: Repeated illegal crossings through Mizoram (a state

already grappling with refugee influxes and drug routes) signal intelligence and enforcement gaps. Each undetected transit normalises foreign mercenaries treating Indian soil as a launchpad.

The Russian tip-off that cracked the case only

underscores how external actors (even rival powers) now monitor India's backyard more effectively than parts of India's own system.

Strategic destabilisation: Myanmar's civil war has already spilled refugees, arms, and militancy into India's Northeast. Adding

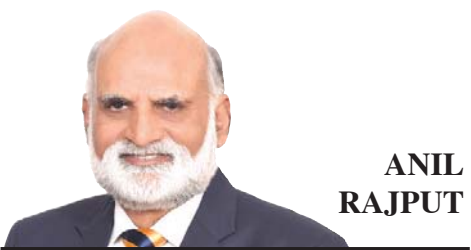
Western/Ukrainian-trained drone units raises the asymmetry: Indian security forces face not just AK-47s but precision loitering munitions and EW-denied zones. This directly threatens the Centre's Act East Policy, infrastructure projects, and the fragile peace accords painstakingly negotiated in Nagaland and Manipur.

In short, VanDyke did not merely film or advise in Myanmar; he allegedly built a deniable pipeline that funnels modern warfare know-how straight into India's internal fault lines. VanDyke's defenders will paint him as a romantic idealist empowering the powerless. The evidence emerging from Delhi's courts suggests something more prosaic and dangerous: a hardened mercenary whose humanitarian brand provides plausible deniability while he professionalises insurgencies on India's doorstep.

VanDyke's arrest is a warning. When filmmakers trade cameras for kill lists and non-profits become training academies for the next generation of drones over Manipur or Mizoram, India's internal security apparatus changes overnight. By arresting a CIA operative, India has sent a curt message that it will no longer tolerate its Northeast being used as a free-fire training ground for foreign mercenaries.

The writer is the Resident Editor of *The Pioneer*

Ram Navami: Devotion, discipline, and its cuisine

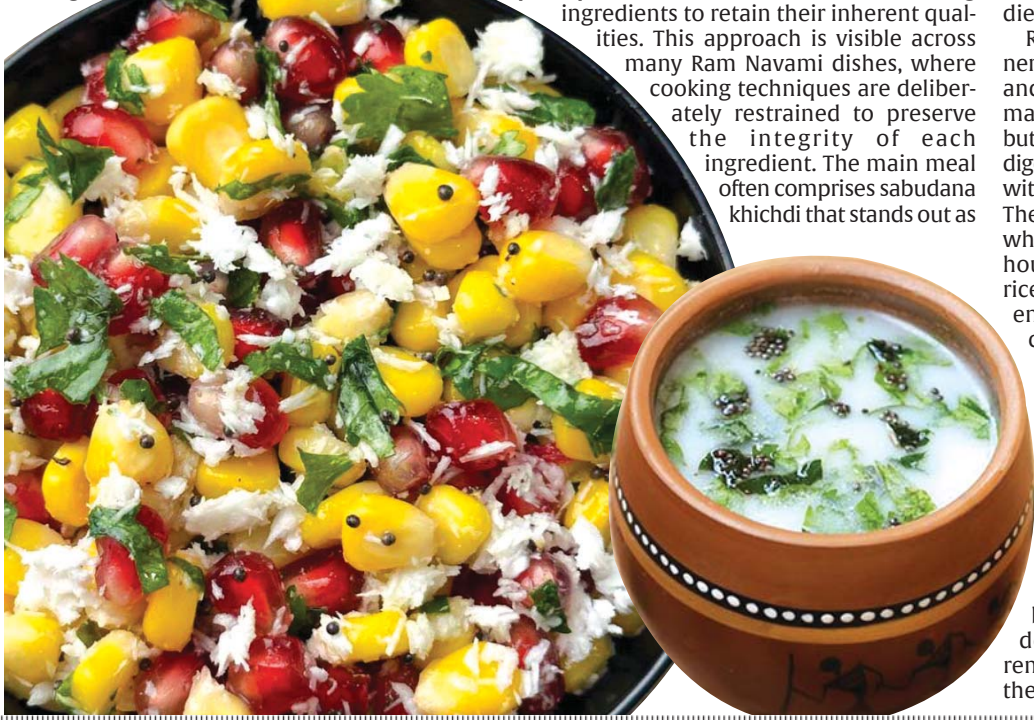


ANIL
RAJPUT

Ram Navami, marking the birth of Lord Ram, commemorates not only the advent of a revered deity but also the ideals that have shaped civilisational thought for centuries. Observed on the ninth day of the bright half of the Chaitra month, the festival unfolds as a moment of profound spiritual significance across India. In Hindu belief, Ram is an incarnation of Vishnu, who takes birth to protect the virtuous and re-establish moral order whenever dharma declines. The festival, therefore, celebrates with joy a cosmic intervention to restore order and righteousness. Homes are sanctified, temples resonate with recitations, and communities gather in prayers and hymns. In this atmosphere, food, regarded as an extension of faith, is prepared with care and devotion where recipes, and methods of preparation align with spiritual intent.

The historical roots of Ram Navami can be traced back to ancient traditions of the Indian subcontinent, where the Ramyana evolved not merely as a literary text but as a guiding framework for ethical living. In remembering and honoring these moral tenets, the teachings are relived and their relevance to modern day life re-affirmed. Fasting assumes a central role in this observance, reflecting both discipline and devotion. Devotees often abstain from grains, onion, garlic, and heavy foods, choosing instead preparations that are light, sattvic, and pure. This dietary restraint reflects the larger philosophical understanding that food influences both body and mind, and that it complements purity in thought. As the day progresses from prayer to family and communal gathering, the cuisine comes into focus as a medium through which devotion is expressed and shared.

Celebrations of Ram Navami in Ayodhya, revered as the birthplace of Lord Ram, is especially immersive and elaborate. The entire town transforms into a sacred landscape of illuminated temples, and a grand shobha yatra (procession) marks the moment of Ram's birth at noon. The atmosphere is devotional yet celebratory, with thousands of pilgrims gathering at ghats along the Sarayu River for ritual bathing



and prayer. What distinguishes Ayodhya's celebration further is its deeply rooted food tradition, which remains strictly sattvic, reflecting the same ideals of restraint, devotion, and harmony that define the life and legacy of Ram.

Across India too, preparations begin in earnest early in the day with prayers offered in temples, recitation of the Ramayana, fasting and processions marking the birth of Lord Ram. Homes are cleaned and decorated, deities are bathed in milk and adorned in fine garments. Sabudana is soaked to the precise softness required for cooking, lentils are rinsed and left to rest, coconut is grated fresh, and spices are carefully laid out. Soon, the kitchen comes into focus. Traditional recipes are recalled by the elders and the younger members learn with patience and attentiveness. What appears to be the preparation of a festive meal becomes the preservation of a living tradition carried through generations with repetition and care.

Among the most widely prepared offerings is panakam, a traditional beverage that holds both ritual and practical significance. Prepared using jaggery dissolved in water, it is flavoured with dry ginger, black pepper, and cardamom, creating a drink that is both cooling and invigorating. The inclusion of spices balances the sweetness of jaggery, making it suitable for the onset of warmer weather that coincides with the festival. This is first offered to the deity before being shared as prasad, reinforcing humility and gratitude, and recognizing that nourishment is a divine blessing, not merely a personal entitlement. Alongside panakam, neer mor or spiced buttermilk is also prepared, particularly in southern India. Yogurt diluted with water is tempered with curry leaves, mustard seeds, and green chillies, creating a light and refreshing drink that aids digestion while offering respite from the heat.

Kosambari, a simple yet nourishing salad of soaked lentils, grated coconut, and cucumber, represents another essential preparation that precedes the main meal. Lentils are soaked with care taken to preserve their natural texture and nutritional value. Tempered lightly with mustard seeds and curry leaves, the dish embodies the principle of minimal intervention, allowing ingredients to retain their inherent qualities. This approach is visible across many Ram Navami dishes, where cooking techniques are deliberately restrained to preserve the integrity of each ingredient. The main meal often comprises sabudana khichdi that stands out as



addition of boiled potatoes provides substance, while a squeeze of lemon adds brightness. The dish is both filling and easy to digest. Similarly, buckwheat or kuttu flour lends itself to a variety of breads such as kuttu ki puri, kuttu ki roti, and lightly pan cooked parathas, while other fasting flours like rajgira and singhara are used to prepare rajgira rotis and singhare ki puris. Alongside these, preparations such as sama ke chawal ki roti and farali thalipeeth further expand the range, each offering a distinct texture while adhering to fasting traditions. These are often paired with aloo sabzi prepared without onion or garlic, where the potato curry is flavoured with cumin, ginger, and green chillies. The potato curry, which acts as an accompaniment, is flavoured with cumin, ginger, and green chillies. Another staple is sama ke chawal, or barnyard millet, which serves as a substitute for rice during fasting. Cooked either as a pulao with mild spices and vegetables or as a kheer with milk and sugar, it demonstrates the adaptability of traditional grains within dietary restrictions.

Rice based preparations also feature prominently. Adapted according to regional traditions and availability of ingredients, the rice dish is made with tamarind, lemon, coconut, and curd but shares a common emphasis on simplicity and digestibility. Akki payasa, a rice pudding prepared with jaggery and coconut milk, offers a variation. The use of coconut milk lends a subtle richness while maintaining a lighter profile. In many households, jaggery pongal is prepared, where rice and lentils are cooked together and sweetened with jaggery, then enriched with ghee, cashews, and raisins. The dish carries both ritual significance and culinary satisfaction, often offered as prasad before being shared.

Lauki ki sabzi, prepared from bottle gourd, is another common dish. Cooked gently with minimal spices, it retains its natural flavour and lightness, aligning with the sattvic nature of the cuisine. Arbi ki tikki, made from colocasia roots, offers a variation in texture. The boiled roots are mashed with spices and shaped into patties before being shallow fried until crisp. The exterior develops a light crust while the interior remains soft, creating a contrast that enhances the eating experience. Similarly, farali patties,

one of the most recognisable dishes associated with fasting. Tapioca pearls are soaked until soft and then cooked with roasted peanuts, cumin, and green chillies. The buckwheat or kuttu flour lends itself to a variety of breads such as kuttu ki puri, kuttu ki roti, and lightly pan cooked parathas, while other fasting flours like rajgira and singhara are used to prepare rajgira rotis and singhare ki puris. Alongside these, preparations such as sama ke chawal ki roti and farali thalipeeth further expand the range, each offering a distinct texture while adhering to fasting traditions. These are often paired with aloo sabzi prepared without onion or garlic, where the potato curry is flavoured with cumin, ginger, and green chillies. The potato curry, which acts as an accompaniment, is flavoured with cumin, ginger, and green chillies. Another staple is sama ke chawal, or barnyard millet, which serves as a substitute for rice during fasting. Cooked either as a pulao with mild spices and vegetables or as a kheer with milk and sugar, it demonstrates the adaptability of traditional grains within dietary restrictions.

often prepared during fasting periods, combine mashed potatoes with a filling of coconut, peanuts, and mild spices, resulting in a dish that is both nourishing and flavourful. Sweet preparations occupy a place of pride in the cuisine of Ram Navami, though they differ in character from the rich desserts of other festivals. Rava kesari, prepared from semolina roasted in ghee and cooked with sugar, water, and saffron, offers a gentle sweetness complemented by the aroma of cardamom. The texture is soft yet structured, and the dish is often garnished with cashews and raisins. Similarly, sabudana kheer and makhana kheer are prepared by simmering soaked tapioca pearls or roasted fox nuts in milk with sugar and cardamom until they reach a creamy consistency. The translucence of sabudana and the soft, porous texture of makhana create desserts that are both light and satisfying. Another frequently prepared dish is sweet potato halwa, where boiled sweet potatoes are mashed and cooked with ghee, jaggery, and cardamom. Coconut laddoos and dry fruit laddoos, made using grated coconut, nuts, and natural sweeteners, are shaped into small spheres that are easy to prepare and distribute. In parts of southern India, aval payasam prepared from flattened rice simmered in milk or jaggery offers a lighter, fragrant variation that complements the sattvic nature of the meal.

Fruit based preparations also assume importance during Ram Navami. Fresh fruits are often consumed directly or incorporated into dishes such as fruit chaat, where seasonal fruits are combined with a light seasoning of rock salt and pepper. Often a dash of lemon is added for flavour. The emphasis on fruits reflects both their availability during the season and their suitability for fasting, offering natural sweetness and hydration.

The diversity of beverages prepared during Ram Navami deserves particular attention. Beyond panakam and buttermilk, drinks such as badam milk are frequently prepared. Almonds soaked and ground into a paste are mixed with milk, saffron, and cardamom, creating a beverage that is both nourishing and aromatic. Tender coconut water is also widely consumed, valued for its natural electrolytes and cooling properties. In some regions, jaggery based sherbets infused with herbs and spices, such as bel sharbat prepared from wood apple, are offered as a refreshing alternative that complements the lightness of the meal. These beverages not only provide hydration but also balance the dietary simplicity of the festival.

Across India, the temple prasad offered on Ram Navami reflects a rich regional diversity, but conforms to the principles of purity and devotion associated with Ram. In North India, especially

around Ayodhya, panakam, panchamrit (a blend of milk, curd, honey, ghee, and sugar), and simple kheer are commonly distributed, symbolizing nourishment and auspiciousness. In Maharashtra, offerings often include sooji halwa and sabudana khichdi, aligning with fasting traditions. Moving south, in states like Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, temples prepare panakam alongside kosambari emphasizing cooling, easily digestible foods suited to the season. In Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, pulihora (amarind rice) and chalmidi (a rice flour and jaggery sweet) are distinctive offerings, blending taste with ritual significance. Eastern regions, including parts of Odisha and West Bengal, favor chuda dahi (flattened rice with curd) and seasonal fruits, reinforcing simplicity and sattvic balance. Despite these regional variations, the essence of prasad remains uniform, food sanctified through offering, shared as grace, and rooted in a timeless cultural ethos.

In its entirety, Ram Navami represents more than a ritual observance. It is recognized as a civilizational observance that binds history, spirituality, and culture into a tradition. The celebration of the birth of Ram is not merely devotional but a reaffirmation of values that have shaped the societal ideals like dharma, restraint, and just conduct across centuries. Its spiritual depth is reflected in prayer, introspection, and the preparation of sattvic cuisines, where purity of food mirrors purity of thought and intent. In an age of rapid change and cultural transformation, I believe that preserving the essence of such festivals becomes essential, not as nostalgia, but as a conscious effort to carry forward a refined moral and cultural inheritance. For future generations, Ram Navami offers not just a story to remember, but a way of life to understand, embody, and sustain.

As evening approaches and the day's observances draw to a close, what remains is a sense of quiet fulfilment. The meals prepared and shared throughout the day leave behind a sense of purity, duty and contentment. In my view, the cuisine of Ram Navami offers a lesson that extends beyond the festival itself. It reminds us that food, when approached with awareness and intention, can become a medium of discipline, gratitude, and connection. It becomes, therefore, our collective responsibility to safeguard these traditions, and carry forward a heritage to ensure that the essence of Ram Navami continues to endure in both spirit and sustenance.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

The science behind morning sunlight and a happier life

RAJESH K PILLANIA

The world celebrates the International Day of Happiness in the month of March. There are many paths to happiness, and morning sunlight is one effective way. Life and the nature surrounding it have an inbuilt system to sustain and grow life, as well as support mental health, well-being, and happiness. Often, we do not realise the importance of nature and its impact on our lives, including mental health and happiness. There are many natural solutions to various aspects of life, including happiness, and this article focuses on the role of morning sunlight in happiness.

Though we have heard about the benefits of morning sunlight from our parents, teachers, and others, we do not realise its importance. To realise this and understand its importance, let us look at the scientific evidence. Research across multiple studies has shown the impact of morning sunlight on happiness, and the most important reasons are listed here.

First, for morning sunlight, one needs to get up early on the road to their hard work, which shows the positive impact of getting up early on health and well-being, a relationship also highlighted in Sleep Medicine research by Professor Charles A. Czeisler at Harvard Medical School, whose studies on human circadian rhythms show that early rising aligned with natural light cycles improves sleep quality, alertness, and overall well-being.

Second, to get up early in the morning, one needs to go to bed early, which helps mitigate the negative impact of going to bed too late, as people today spend a lot of time on various screens, and this is not good for mental health and well-being, a concern also supported by Public Health research by Professor Charles F. Czeisler at Harvard Medical School, whose work on sleep and electronic device exposure shows that excessive evening screen use disrupts sleep and harms psychological health.

Third, research shows that getting up early and looking at the morning sunlight helps reduce cortisol, the main stress hormone, a finding supported by Neuroscience research by Professor Andrew J Huberman at Stanford University, whose work on light exposure demonstrates that early morning sunlight helps regulate the body's stress response and stabilises cortisol rhythms.

Fourth, research shows that getting up early in the



“Happiness is like a butterfly which, when pursued, is always beyond our grasp, but, if you will sit down quietly, may alight upon you”
- Nathaniel Hawthorne

morning and spending time in nature helps in the release of serotonin, a very important hormone-the happiness hormone-for mood stabilisation and feeling good, a relationship documented in Psychiatry research by Professor Michael Terman at Columbia University, whose clinical studies on light exposure show that natural morning light increases serotonin activity and improves mood.

Fifth, research shows the positive impact of morning sunlight levels on feelings of well-being, mental health, and physical health, a pattern also reported in Environmental Health

research by Professor Richard J. Weller at the University of Edinburgh, whose studies demonstrate that sunlight exposure supports cardiovascular health and overall physiological well-being.

Sixth, human life is busy, and during the day and evenings one is surrounded by many people, but by getting up early to see the morning sunrise and morning sunlight, one can find time for oneself, including self-reflection and self-improvement, which helps in mental and physical health and overall well-being, an idea also supported by Positive Psychology research by Professor Sonja Lyubomirsky at the University of California, Riverside, whose studies show that quiet personal reflection and intentional morning routines significantly enhance happiness and life satisfaction.

Seventh, not only modern research but also traditional knowledge systems and traditional medicine systems highlight the role of morning sunlight in happiness. This is backed up by research from Professor Andrew Weil at the University



of Arizona, whose work on traditional healing and healthy living shows that old practices in Ayurveda and other traditional health systems focus on getting morning sunlight to keep our body clocks on track, lift our mood, and support both physical and mental health. There are many other research studies showing the positive impact of morning sunlight on happiness and well-being. This is something which is easily available to us and costs no money.

Let us celebrate by starting to experience and enjoy morning sunlight for a healthier and happier life!

(The author is a Professor of Strategy at the Management Development Institute, Gurgaon. He is popularly known as India's Happiness Professor and his latest work is *The Indian Practice of Happiness: Secrets from Centenarians*)

The Pursuit of Happiness

The Divine has given you all the small pleasures in the world but has kept bliss to Himself. Once you receive bliss, then everything else is joyful. Without bliss, any joy in the world does not stay

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

The sole search of every being is happiness. Whenever one is searching, whatever one is searching, one is looking for happiness — whether it is spiritual or material, whether it is in the movies, bars, or in the church or temple; whether it is winning a war, earning more money, getting famous, having more power, or sex. The search simply is for happiness. And here is the secret — the Divine is all happiness and bliss. The Divine wants you to be happy. God wants to see you full of enthusiasm, joy, compassion, and happiness. But we keep postponing our happiness.

An adolescent thinks he will be happy when he goes to college. Once in college, he thinks he will be happy when he starts earning. Then he thinks he will be happy once he is married. Once he is married, the desire is to have children. Once children are born, then you want them to grow up well for you to be happy. The story goes on, and that special day never arrives. All of one's life is spent preparing to be happy someday in the future. It is like making a bed all night but having no time to sleep. Instead of preparing to be happy all the time, let us make our conscience happy now and remain naturally happy, like children are. The Divine is trying His best; He has created so many things for us to be happy. But God only helps those who help themselves. So every day make a resolution: “Today, I am just going to be happy, come what may. I will not let anything disturb my happiness. I am going to be content, happy now. I will not plan for happiness in the future.”

If you observe the nature of our future plans, you see that you plan to enjoy, celebrate, and do things that enhance your happiness. Nobody plans to be miserable. All our plans are to enjoy and uplift the spirit. Then why do we want to postpone it for tomorrow? Why do we not do it now? Misery needs a hook or a reason to exist, but happiness does not need a reason.

Happiness is our true nature. It is the state of our being when there is neither stress nor wants. There is a scientific study that says a baby smiles a few hundred times a day, and the number of times an adult smiles is in double digits. We need to ponder on this—what is it that takes away this natural gift of humanity, this smile from our faces?

‘Santosha’ or contentment enhances happiness. Contentment is not a natural tendency in adults; one has to practise it. Being unconditionally happy is a practice. “Come what may, today I am going to smile. Everything is going to vanish and disappear, so what? Let me at least be happy.”

As children, we did not have to practise it because contentment was our very nature. We were content when we had our food, good sleep, and some toys to play with. But as we grew up, we moved away from it. And so contentment has to be practised now.

Knowing the two types of happiness can also



“THE HAPPINESS OF ONE’S MIND. WHEN ONE ACCEPTS PEOPLE AND SITUATIONS AS THEY ARE AND MOVES IN KNOWLEDGE, THEN HAPPINESS BLOSSOMS IN THE MIND”
-GURUDEV

help uplift your spirit. There are two types of happiness. One is how we feel when we receive something. When we get a compliment, we feel happy. When we get a gift, we feel happy. This type of happiness is infant happiness. We were born with this type of happiness. Every child loves to receive gifts. But we cannot remain here forever.

There is another level of happiness—the happiness of giving that we find in our grandmothers or mothers at home. What do we see? When children come home for holidays, mothers prepare many dishes, and their joy is to feed their children. Mothers and grandmothers may not even get to eat it, but it does not reduce their happiness. So there is happiness in giving, contributing, and sharing. We all have to graduate from the happiness of receiving to the happiness of giving. The joy of giving is a mature joy. It lasts for a long time. It makes society a divine society.

We need to focus more on our mental and spiritual happiness than on the worldly or social kind. Happiness can be experienced at three levels.

One is happiness in society, in the environment. This is what everybody thinks happiness is—to derive happiness from others in society. But that is a limited and temporary sense of happiness. How would you feel in a place where everybody around you thinks only about themselves? Do you like to be in such a group where there is no sharing, no sense of belongingness, and no happiness? Again, here we need to come from a space of belonging and sharing.

The second is the happiness of one's mind. When one accepts people and situations as they are and moves in knowledge, then happiness blossoms in the mind.

The third level is the happiness of the soul. This level of happiness dawns upon us when the soul is united with the Divine. When the soul is united with the entire cosmos, then we experience ultimate happiness. When there are no two, in deep meditation, we experience the deepest happiness.

The Divine has given you all the small pleasures in the world but has kept bliss to Himself. Once you receive bliss, then everything else is joyful.

Without bliss, any joy in the world does not stay.

All the three levels of happiness are interlinked. When you are totally united with the Divine, you cannot but experience one hundred per cent fulfilment on the second and the first levels. Then you cannot but serve society because everybody becomes part of you and part of the Divine. When you start serving and stop overthinking all the time about yourself, mental satisfaction dawns naturally. The mind also feels happy and relaxed, and it creates such a joyous environment around you.

Service is a way to achieve happiness. I keep telling parents to help children inculcate the attitude to serve. For example, parents should give them things and ask them to distribute them. Children have a natural tendency to share. It must be encouraged. Tell them to go and serve food to others so that the sense of service and community will grow in children.

If we think only about ourselves—me and mine, “What will happen to me?”—the mind shrinks. Whenever the mind shrinks, it is bound to bring unhappiness. And when the mind expands, it brings joy. The art of pursuing happiness is to expand our perspectives, serve, and live in expanded consciousness. Happiness and contentment are right within us. All you need to do is just relax and go within.



HAPPINESS IS OUR TRUE NATURE. IT IS THE STATE OF OUR BEING WHEN THERE IS NEITHER STRESS NOR WANTS. THERE IS A SCIENTIFIC STUDY THAT SAYS A BABY SMILES A FEW HUNDRED TIMES A DAY, AND THE NUMBER OF TIMES AN ADULT SMILES IS IN DOUBLE DIGITS. WE NEED TO PONDER ON THIS — WHAT IS IT THAT TAKES AWAY THIS NATURAL GIFT OF HUMANITY, THIS SMILE FROM OUR FACES? ‘SANTOSHA’ OR CONTENTMENT ENHANCES HAPPINESS. CONTENTMENT IS NOT A NATURAL TENDENCY IN ADULTS; ONE HAS TO PRACTISE IT. BEING UNCONDITIONALLY HAPPY IS A PRACTICE. “COME WHAT MAY, TODAY I AM GOING TO SMILE. EVERYTHING IS GOING TO VANISH AND DISAPPEAR, SO WHAT? LET ME AT LEAST BE HAPPY.”

Feminism in India’s ancient past

TEAM AGENDA

At a time when feminism is often perceived through borrowed intellectual frameworks, *Women in the Womb of Time* (WITWOT) offers a refreshing and deeply rooted alternative—one that seeks to rediscover feminism within the vast and layered traditions of ancient India. Moving beyond the binaries of modern ideological debates, the book begins with a provocative question: why feminism, and not masculinism? This inquiry becomes the point of departure for a rich exploration into the origins, distortions, and possibilities of gender discourse across time.

The work does not merely attempt to trace the historical subjugation of women; rather, it strives to uncover the complex interplay of power, agency, and identity that shaped women's lives in ancient Indian society. Drawing upon an impressive range of primary sources—from the Vedas and Upanishads to the Epics, Manusmriti, Arthashastra, Kamasutra, and Dharmashastras—the book reconstructs a nuanced narrative in which women are not only subjects of patriarchy but also active participants in shaping intellectual, cultural, and economic life.

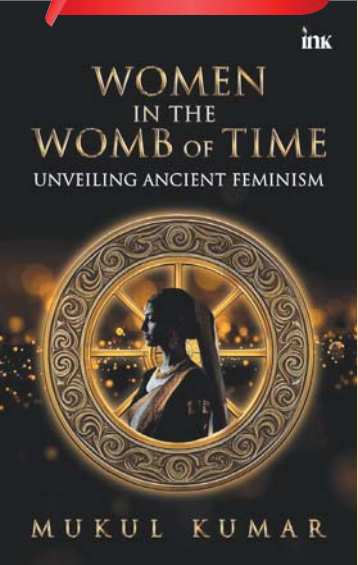
The opening chapter sets the philosophical tone by redefining feminism not merely as a political or legal struggle for equality, but as a broader humanistic quest for dignity, wholeness, and self-realisation. It situates gender inequality within the deeper currents of human evolution, examining how biological roles, division of labour, and material conditions contributed to the gradual emergence of patriarchal structures.

By engaging with thinkers such as Karl Marx, Simone de Beauvoir, and Judith Butler, the author builds a compelling theoretical framework while remaining anchored in the Indian context.

What distinguishes WITWOT is its refusal to romanticise the past. Instead, it presents a balanced account that acknowledges both the reverence and repression of women across different periods. The Vedic age, often idealised for its relative gender parity, is examined alongside



NEW ARRIVAL



Title: Women in the Womb of Time
Author: Mukul Kumar
MRP: ₹ 799
Publisher: INK

later texts like Manusmriti, which codified hierarchical norms. Similarly, works such as the Arthashastra and Kamasutra are reinterpreted not just as administrative or erotic manuals, but as texts that reveal women's engagement with power, economy, and desire.

The book also ventures into less explored territories, including hetero-

dox traditions such as Buddhism, and the insights gleaned from epigraphic and numismatic evidence. These sources collectively illuminate the multiple ways in which women exercised agency—whether as scholars, householders, political actors, or spiritual seekers. The narrative thus challenges the monolithic image of the “second sex”, revealing instead a dynamic spectrum of female experiences.

Endorsements by eminent scholars underscore the significance of this contribution. The work has been praised for its ability to “reimagine Indian feminism on its own terms”, and for problematising the very foundations of feminist discourse in both historical and global contexts. It compels readers to rethink not only the past but also the present, urging a move towards a more equitable future grounded in indigenous intellectual traditions.

Ultimately, *Women in the Womb of Time* is not just a historical study; it is a call to intellectual reclamation. By delving into the “womb of time”, it seeks to recover voices that have long been muted and to weave them into a living, evolving narrative of empowerment. In doing so, the book bridges the past and the present, offering a vision of feminism that is both rooted and revolutionary—one that draws strength from history while shaping the contours of a more inclusive tomorrow.

Portrait of India’s changing middle class

TEAM AGENDA

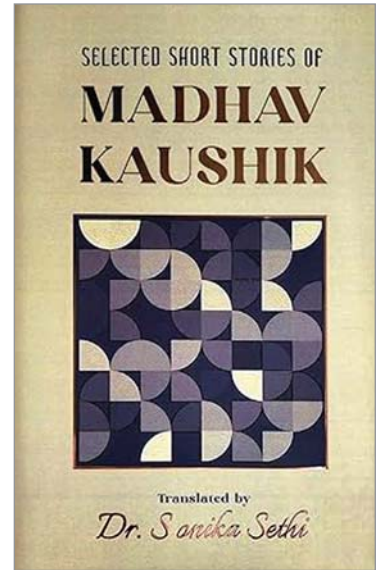
Selected Short Stories of Madhav Kaushik, translated into English by Sonika Sethi, brings together twenty-five stories by one of Hindi literature's respected contemporary voices. Recently honoured with the Kala Ratna Award 2026 in the Short Story (English) category, the collection opens a thoughtful window into the emotional and social landscape of India's middle class.

At the heart of Madhav Kaushik's writing lies a deep engagement with the ordinary lives of people negotiating a changing society. His characters inhabit familiar settings—homes, offices, neighbourhood clubs, and public institutions—but the conflicts they experience are far from ordinary. Through subtle observation and psychological nuance, Kaushik explores loneliness, moral uncertainty, fading values, and the quiet resilience that allows individuals to carry on.

Many of the protagonists in these stories appear caught between past and present. They are reflective individuals who remember a time when relationships seemed simpler and social structures more stable. Yet they must navigate a contemporary world marked by rapid change, shifting expectations, and an increasing sense of isolation. Kaushik's narratives capture this tension with remarkable sensitivity, revealing how nostalgia for the past often coexists with the pressures of the present.

A recurring motif across the collection is the transformation of the Indian middle class. Traditional bonds—family ties, neighbourhood connections, and institutional loyalties—are shown gradually eroding under the weight of modern aspirations and social mobility. Through everyday situations and quiet emotional moments, the stories depict individuals confronting disappointment, helplessness, and sometimes moral compromise. Yet beneath these tensions runs a persistent thread of human dignity and inner resistance.

At the same time, Kaushik demonstrates a sharp satirical edge. Stories such as *FIR*, *The Option*, *Dangal*, and *The Officers Club* introduce humour and irony into the narrative landscape. These pieces examine bureau-



Title: Selected Short Stories of Madhav Kaushik
Translated by: Sonika Sethi
MRP: ₹ 350
Publisher: Pakshighar Prakashanee

“THROUGH UNDERSTATED STORYTELLING AND DEEPLY HUMAN CHARACTERS, MADHAV KAUSHIK CAPTURES THE ANXIETIES, CONTRADICTIONS AND QUIET RESILIENCE OF INDIA'S EVOLVING MIDDLE CLASS”

gradually from the rhythms of everyday life. The stories unfold through reflection, memory, and subtle conflict, revealing the anxieties and aspirations that shape contemporary social existence.

Sonika Sethi's translation plays a significant role in bringing these narratives to a wider readership. Her English rendering preserves the cultural texture, emotional cadence, and contextual nuance of the Hindi originals while maintaining clarity and readability. The translation succeeds in retaining the spirit of Kaushik's storytelling without sacrificing accessibility for English-language readers.

Together, the stories form a reflective portrait of a society in quiet transition. Through understated storytelling and deeply human characters, *Selected Short Stories of Madhav Kaushik* invites readers to reflect on memory, change, and the fragile balance between tradition and modernity.